

A DOCUMENTARY HISTORY OF THE
UNIVERSITY OF VIRGINIA'S FIRST LIBRARY
AND ITS JEFFERSONIAN CATALOGS

by

SAMUEL V. LEMLEY, NEAL D. CURTIS,
AND MADELINE ZEHNDER*

IN 1984, a manuscript catalog of Thomas Jefferson's library resurfaced at the Library of Congress. The rediscovery was announced by Douglas L. Wilson, who proposed that the catalog—dated 1823—reestablished Jefferson's system of library organization, lost after a fair copy of Jefferson's catalog disappeared with the transfer of his library to Congress in 1815. This 1823 manuscript filled an archival void in Jefferson studies and advanced a new and enduring view of Jefferson's book collecting habits in the final decade of his life (1815-26). In a subsequent analysis and edition of the rediscovered catalog, written with James Gilreath, Wilson affirmed that the document in question was a copy of Jefferson's catalog drawn up to reestablish the arrangement of his books, "in his own order."¹

Gilreath and Wilson's account captures the first part of a complex story. In this article, we offer an alternative analysis of the 1823 catalog. Drawing on new materials, including another recently resurfaced Jeffersonian booklist, we argue that the surviving textual, bibliographical, and provenance evidence repositions the 1823 catalog as the originating document of the University of Virginia's library. Not only does the catalog reconstruct the arrangement of Jefferson's

* The evidence examined here was first presented in a talk delivered at the annual meeting of the Bibliographical Society of the University of Virginia (BSUVA) in March, 2018. We would like to thank the BSUVA for their support. We are grateful in particular for the encouragement, editorial wizardry, and care of David Vander Meulen. We would also like to thank the indefatigable staff of the Albert and Shirley Small Special Collections Library at the University of Virginia: David Whitesell, Molly Schwartzburg, Regina Rush, Penny White, Heather Riser, George Riser, Joseph Azizi, Gayle Cooper, and Krystal Appiah. This project would not have been possible without their patient assistance. Our research was supported at various points by the Kenan Endowment Fund of the Academical Village, the Jefferson Trust, and the Robert H. Smith International Center for Thomas Jefferson Studies.

1. The first announcement of Douglas Wilson's discovery appeared in James Gilreath's review of E. Millicent Sowerby's *Catalogue of the Library of Thomas Jefferson* (Washington, DC: The Library of Congress, 1952). See Gilreath, "Sowerby Revirescent and Revised," *The Papers of the Bibliographical Society of America* 78, no. 2 (1984): 219-32. There, Gilreath observes that "Wilson's [forthcoming] article offers another document which contains a strikingly different order for many chapters [of Jefferson's catalog]" (230). An analysis followed in 1989: *Thomas Jefferson's Library: A Catalogue of Books in His Own Order* (Washington, DC: Library of Congress).

personal library at Monticello; it also lays out the epistemological and disciplinary categories that would shape the development and future growth of a major early American university. Indeed, scholars including Wilson and Endrina Tay have previously proposed a relationship between the university's library and 1823 catalog, with Wilson noting that the catalog was intended "apparently for the University of Virginia."² By collating and examining all of the book lists and catalogs Jefferson took part in compiling from 1815 to 1826, we consider the textual imbrications and intricacies of this link, charting the 1823 catalog's role in the compilation of later catalogs for the University of Virginia's first library.

In addition to offering a fuller account of the 1823 manuscript's origins and re-inscriptions, we also put forward an analysis of how Jefferson's extant book lists from this period are textually related. Jefferson made (or had made) a large number of catalogs, bibliographic inventories, and lists of books over the course of his life, and the resulting variety of organizational schemata, artistic and intellectual disciplines, and content can stymie generalizing treatment.³ To chart the textual filiation of the catalogs we examine here, we construct an annotated stemma over the course of this article. What emerges is both a more comprehensive view of how the University of Virginia's library came to be, and evidence of Jefferson's attempts to construct and perpetuate a totalizing vision of knowledge-in-books across all of his library-building projects.

ORIGINS: THE 1783 CATALOG & THE 1812 FAIR COPY

An inveterate, compulsive arranger of books, Jefferson began compiling what would become the catalog of his Monticello library sometime after a fire destroyed his first library at Shadwell in February, 1770.⁴ This catalog is traditionally labelled the **1783 catalog** and lists books Jefferson acquired during his political career and in the first years of his retirement (1809-12).⁵ The date traditionally assigned to the catalog, 1783, refers to a manuscript tally of books in Jefferson's hand, dated March 6, 1783, that appears on the catalog's fifth

2. Douglas L. Wilson, "Sowerby Revisited: The Unfinished Catalogue of Thomas Jefferson's Library," *The William and Mary Quarterly* 41, no. 4 (October 1984): 624. On the link between the 1823 manuscript and Jefferson's list-making for the University of Virginia's first library, see Endrina Tay, "Forming the Body of a Library Based on the 'Illimitable Freedom of the Human Mind,'" in *The Founding of Thomas Jefferson's University*, ed. John A. Ragosta, Peter S. Onuf, and Andrew J. O'Shaughnessy (Charlottesville, VA: University of Virginia Press, 2019): 208-23.

3. Sowerby's "Compiler's Preface" is still the authoritative source for Jefferson's habits as cataloguer and collector. Sowerby's "Sources and Reference Books Used in This Catalogue," in *Catalogue of the Library of Thomas Jefferson*, 5:215-22, is similarly informative.

4. See Wilson, *Jefferson's Books* (Charlottesville, VA: Thomas Jefferson Memorial Foundation, 1996), 18-19.

5. "1783 Catalog of Books," *Thomas Jefferson Papers: An Electronic Archive* (Boston: Massachusetts Historical Society, 2003), <https://www.masshist.org/thomasjeffersonpapers/catalog1783/>. The catalog was presented to the Massachusetts Historical Society in June 1898 by Thomas Jefferson's great-grandson, Thomas Jefferson Coolidge. See Sowerby, "Sources and Reference Books," 215.

page.⁶ Riddled with what E. Millicent Sowerby describes as “erasures and semi-erasures,” the 1783 catalog was a working document that functioned as the primary reference tool and inventory of Jefferson’s library at least until 1812, when Jefferson made a fair copy of the catalog that would eventually accompany his books to Congress in 1815.⁷

Jefferson intended to have the **1812 catalog** printed for reasons of both personal convenience and future preservation. Writing to Thomas Cooper on July 10, 1812, Jefferson refers to the fair copy: “I am making a fair copy of the Catalogue of my library, which I mean to have printed merely for the use of the library.”⁸ Jefferson’s portrayal of the 1812 catalog as “useful” may reflect his need for an easier-to-navigate alternative to the 1783 catalog, which by 1812 was a confusing and palimpsestic document that listed books he no longer owned and omitted books he had since acquired. Jefferson’s desire to print the 1812 catalog—a remediation that would have enabled him to distribute copies to interested readers—also reveals his interest in the library’s posthumous existence and utility; at last, the collection that the 1812 catalog would describe was nearing a long-elusive stasis. Tacit in Jefferson’s letter to Cooper is the fact that he had begun to view his collection of books as a coherent and relatively fixed whole, ready to enter the permanent record.

By the time Jefferson began work on the 1812 catalog, he had already envisioned an institutional future for his library. In a letter to Cooper, dated January 16, 1814, Jefferson writes: “I have long had under contemplation, & been collecting materials for the plan of an university in Virginia.” Jefferson adds that this university (not yet *the* University of Virginia, but only *an* university in Virginia) might acquire his library “on their own terms,” thus securing a collection of “about 7. or 8 thousand volumes” and “the best ... of it’s [sic] size probably in America.”⁹ Jefferson’s letter expresses a typical immodesty about his books, but it also indicates that he had come to anticipate the dispersal of his library—an act that would require a legible and comprehensive inventory of its contents. However, war intervened, and the destruction of Washington in 1814 by British troops precipitated the library’s sale to Congress in 1815.

In addition to the presumably improved functionality it offered, the 1812 fair copy introduced a new organizational schema, superseding an earlier version that organized the 1783 catalog. In retirement, Jefferson continued to refine and modify the order of his shelves and the headings under which he classed his

6. “1783 Catalog of Books,” accessed April 7, 2021. See also Sowerby, “Sources and Reference Books,” 215.

7. Sowerby, “Sources and Reference Books,” 215.

8. “Thomas Jefferson to Thomas Cooper, 10 July 1812,” *Founders Online*, National Archives, <https://founders.archives.gov/documents/Jefferson/03-05-02-0179>.

9. “Thomas Jefferson to Thomas Cooper, 16 January 1814,” *Founders Online*, National Archives, <https://founders.archives.gov/documents/Jefferson/03-07-02-0071>. Tay cites an earlier letter sent to Littleton Tazewell, indicating that Jefferson had begun envisioning a library for a planned university in Virginia at least as early as 1805. Tay, “Forming the Body of a Library,” 209, n. 14. See also “From Thomas Jefferson to Littleton W. Tazewell, 5 January 1805,” *Founders Online*, National Archives, <https://founders.archives.gov/documents/Jefferson/99-01-02-0958>. [This is an *Early Access* document from *The Papers of Thomas Jefferson*. It is not an authoritative final version.]

books. While the 1783 catalog employed a forty-six-subject schema, the 1812 fair copy employed a forty-four-subject alternative. Both schemata, however, classed their subjects under Jefferson's tripartite division of knowledge based on Francis Bacon's three parts of learning: "History/Memory," "Philosophy/Reason," and "Fine Arts/Imagination."

Although the 1812 fair copy is presumed lost, evidence for this schematic change survives in the printed catalog that then-Librarian of Congress George Watterston produced in 1815 following the sale of Jefferson's books to Congress.¹⁰ According to his correspondence with Jefferson, Watterston based the new catalog's arrangement of subject chapters on the 1812 fair copy, informing Jefferson in a letter dated October 13, 1815, that "I have preserved your arrangement, as one that I think excellent."¹¹ Watterston's printed **1815 catalog** thus shares its subject categories with its lost manuscript predecessor. This later catalog makes clear that the reduction of subject headings from 46 to 44 chapters was the result of shifting, compressing, and subdividing the original 1783 classifications. In all, the 1812 and 1815 catalogs removed five chapters that appear in the 1783 catalog and added three more. Figure 1 maps the additions, deletions, expansions, and combinations of subject chapters that occur between the 1783 and 1812/15 schemata. As shown, most of the alterations occur in the final section of Jefferson's tripartite scheme, "Fine Arts/Imagination." While the motives behind these changes are undocumented and obscure, the alterations appear to subsume the most idiosyncratic chapters into more general categories, rendering the new schema more applicable and useful to an institutional collection of books; they might also have merely combined sparsely populated chapters to form more general categories containing more volumes, or divided overpopulated or thematically cluttered chapters into more manageable subchapters. Regardless, in adopting these alterations, Watterston deferred to Jefferson and emulated the 1812 fair copy in making the 1815 printed catalog.

There was one glaring difference between the 1812 and 1815 catalogs, however. As Watterston informed Jefferson, "I have introduced but one alteration & that is in arrangeing [sic] each chap: alphabetically ... it gives them a uniformity of appearance quite agreeable [sic] to the eye."¹² At Monticello, where three newly printed copies of the catalog had arrived early in 1816, Watterston's choice to retain Jefferson's subject headings no doubt met with approval. Jefferson demurred, however, on the alphabetical sequence of books in each of the catalog's forty-four chapters—a change that expunged a system of arrangement that,

10. The 1815 printed catalog was prepared sometime between the manuscript's arrival at the Library of Congress in July and a letter of 13 October from Watterston informing Jefferson that "the catalogue is now in press ... in a few weeks it will be published" ("George Watterston to Thomas Jefferson, 13 October 1815," *Founders Online*, National Archives, <https://founders.archives.gov/documents/Jefferson/03-09-02-0064-0001>). Jefferson's letter alerting Watterston that the library and the 1812 fair copy of the catalog had been sent is dated 7 May 1815: "You will recieve my library arranged very perfectly in the order observed in the Catalogue, which I have sent with it" ("Thomas Jefferson to George Watterston, 7 May 1815," *Founders Online*, National Archives, <https://founders.archives.gov/documents/Jefferson/03-08-02-0376>).

11. George Watterston to Thomas Jefferson, 13 October 1815.

12. George Watterston to Thomas Jefferson, 13 October 1815.

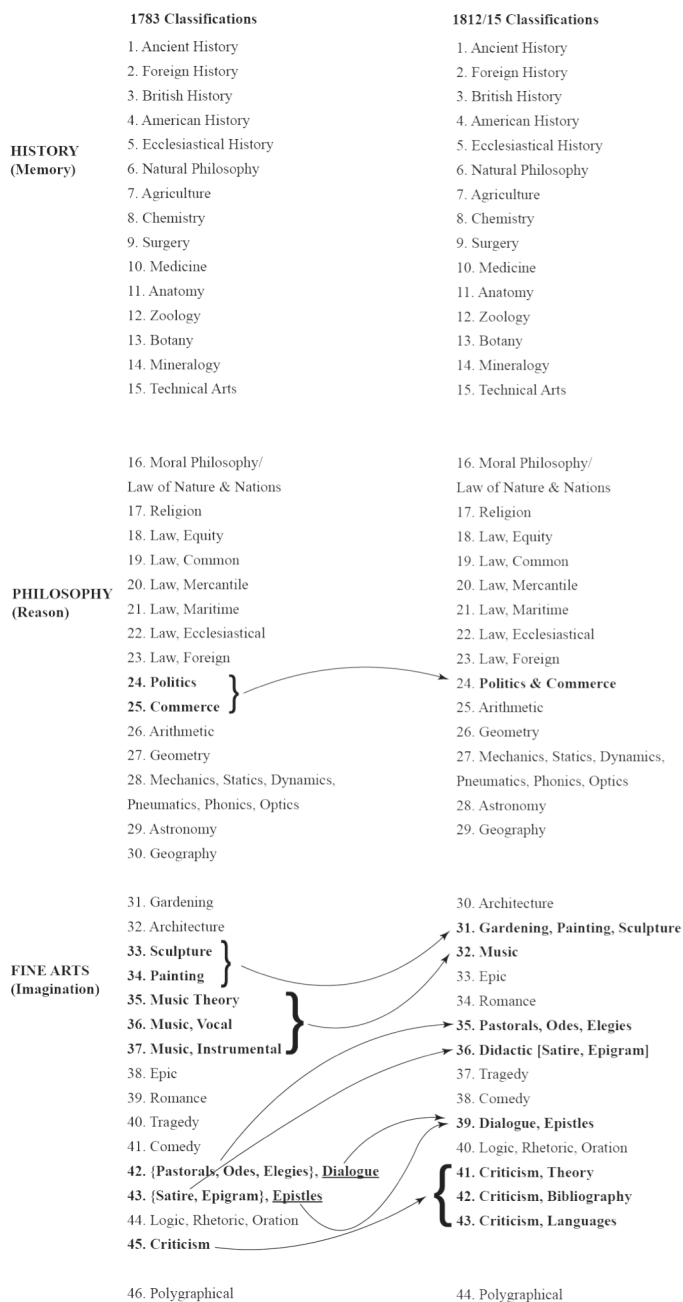


FIGURE 1. Jefferson’s revisions to his system of classification, introduced in the 1812 fair copy. George Watterston followed this revised schema in the 1815 printed catalog.

as he explained in a subsequent letter to Watterston, was “sometimes analytical, sometimes chronological, & sometimes a combination of both.”¹³ In spite of Jefferson’s reservations, he admitted in the same letter that an “alphabetical arrangement may be more convenient to readers generally.” There is no record of Jefferson asking Watterston to return the 1812 fair copy, and when President Andrew Jackson had Watterston replaced in 1829, the outgoing librarian took Jefferson’s fair copy with him, reporting to Asher Robbins, Chairman of the Joint Committee on the Library, that it had been given “to me by Mr Jefferson, if I could save it from the printer. It was of no use to him or to the Lib[rar]y & I therefore claim it as my property.”¹⁴ Its fate remains unknown.

AFTER 1815: GILREATH & WILSON REVISITED

The rest, according to Gilreath and Wilson, is history: Watterston’s retaining the 1812 fair copy “has meant that the arrangement of individual books that was so important to Jefferson has been lost.”¹⁵ In other words, after the 1815 printed catalog imposed an alphabetical arrangement in place of Jefferson’s “chronological-analytical” system, the 1812 fair copy became the last surviving record of Jefferson’s intended ordering of his books. Taking this as its premise, Gilreath and Wilson’s *Thomas Jefferson’s Library* announced that

the restoration of Jefferson’s order has been made possible by the rediscovery of a manuscript [in the Rare Books Division of the Library of Congress] that was commissioned and corrected by Jefferson for the purpose of reconstructing the original catalog order that had been obliterated in Watterston’s printed congressional catalog of 1815. For many years, [the rediscovered manuscript] was mistakenly labeled as a catalog of the library at the University of Virginia and may have been intended for its collections. Bound with the manuscript catalog, which was clearly not in Jefferson’s hand, was a copy of the 1815 printed catalog.... A close comparison of the manuscript and the 1815 printed catalog makes clear ... that the two contain the same entries, though each is arranged in a different order.¹⁶

Gilreath and Wilson go on to observe that the rediscovered manuscript was copied at Jefferson’s behest by Nicholas P. Trist in 1823, citing an exchange of letters between Trist and Jefferson in evidence of the circumstances of the manuscript’s origin.¹⁷

Since the publication of *Thomas Jefferson’s Library* in 1989, no one has significantly modified or revisited Gilreath and Wilson’s account, and their assessment of the provenance and production history of the **1823 catalog** has remained

13. “Thomas Jefferson to George Watterston, 2 March 1816,” *Founders Online*, National Archives, <https://founders.archives.gov/documents/Jefferson/03-09-02-0366>. In an earlier letter to Watterston, Jefferson observed that the alphabetical arrangement of libraries was “very unsatisfactory” (“Thomas Jefferson to George Watterston, 7 May 1815,” *Founders Online*, National Archives, <https://founders.archives.gov/documents/Jefferson/03-08-02-0376>).

14. Quoted in Sowerby, “Sources and Reference Books,” 216. It is possible that the 1812 fair copy was kept by Watterston’s family and eventually lost, as it does not appear in any extant records or collections. Watterston’s letter to Robbins is dated 30 February 1830.

15. Gilreath and Wilson, *Thomas Jefferson’s Library*, 4.

16. Gilreath and Wilson, *Thomas Jefferson’s Library*, 5.

17. Gilreath and Wilson, *Thomas Jefferson’s Library*, 6.

authoritative in the intervening decades.¹⁸ Their case regarding the rediscovered catalog rests on three arguments. First, Gilreath and Wilson contend that the 1823 catalog derived from a now-lost annotated copy of the 1815 catalog, writing that Trist compiled the 1823 catalog after Jefferson sent Trist

a copy of the 1815 printed catalog that he [Jefferson] had annotated to indicate his intended order for the books. Trist then compiled the manuscript catalog ... and sent it, along with Jefferson's annotated copy of the printed catalog, back to Jefferson when the job was completed. Though Jefferson's marked 1815 printed catalog has not been found and is presumed lost, we now have the Trist manuscript copy that was precious to Jefferson because it reclaimed the results of an important undertaking that had nearly been lost—his painstaking and distinctive ordering of the books in his magnificent library.¹⁹

Second, Gilreath and Wilson suggest that the primary motivation behind Trist's manuscript was to "reconstruct" Jefferson's "original" order erased by Watterston. Although they do not elaborate on its potential applications after Jefferson received it in late 1823, they do note that "[i]t is not surprising that Jefferson's thoughts should have turned to book catalogs in 1823 since he was actively engaged in organizing the University of Virginia library."²⁰ Third, they conclude that the Trist manuscript's longstanding association with the University of Virginia was a "mistake," allowing only that it "may have been intended for its collections." In what follows we reevaluate these points in turn, beginning with the question of the copy text Trist used to create the manuscript catalog in 1823. New evidence suggests that Gilreath and Wilson's pathbreaking scholarship tells only the first part of a fascinating narrative, one that ends with the formation of the University of Virginia's first library and its installation on the shelves of the University's Rotunda.

THE COPY TEXT OF THE 1823 TRIST CATALOG

In reading the Jefferson-Trist correspondence from 1823 and 1824, Gilreath and Wilson reasonably assume that Jefferson provided Trist with a copy of the 1815 printed catalog to transcribe. As they record in *Thomas Jefferson's Library*:

18. The Library of Congress catalog entry for the Trist manuscript in question paraphrases Gilreath and Wilson, stating that "Trist apparently worked from a copy of the printed 1815 Library of Congress catalogue specially marked by Jefferson in order to restore, in place of its alphabetical arrangement of each subject category, the original order of entries that Jefferson preferred" (Thomas Jefferson and Nicholas Philip Trist "Catalogue" [1823], Manuscript / Mixed Material, Thomas Jefferson Collection, Rare Book and Special Collections Division, The Library of Congress, Washington, D.C., Z997 J48 J44 1823, <https://www.loc.gov/item/87204942/>). In similar terms, the Thomas Jefferson's Libraries project at the International Center for Jefferson Studies at Monticello writes that "Jefferson commissioned Nicholas Philip Trist to recreate a list of the books sold to Congress in the order he had originally defined," citing Gilreath and Wilson ("Trist Catalogue," <http://tjlibraries.monticello.org/tjandreading/trist.html>, accessed April 7, 2021). Tay has recently noted that Trist's 1823 manuscript served Jefferson as a reference list "as he began to plan the library collection for the University of Virginia," though does not explore how these catalogs were textually linked or related. ("Forming the Body of a Library," 221 n32). We return to this point below.

19. Gilreath and Wilson, *Thomas Jefferson's Library*, 6.

20. *Ibid.*

Writing to Jefferson from Louisiana on October 18, 1823, Trist says: "I avail myself of the first opportunity that offers to return your catalogue, the absence of which will have proved, I fear, a greater inconvenience than can be compensated by the copy I have made." Jefferson replied on his eighty-first birthday, April 13, 1824: "The catalogues, printed and ms. were safely received. The last has given you more trouble than I ought to have subjected you to. It is very precious to me, and I am thankful to you for it."²¹

Comparing the 1823 and 1815 catalogs reveals that their entries match exactly (though in a different order), with no additions and only very few apparently accidental deletions. Accordingly, the Trist catalog could not have been produced without a copy of the 1815 printed catalog on hand. But while Gilreath and Wilson interpret the "manuscript" catalog Jefferson cites here to be the manuscript *copy* that Trist made (i.e., the 1823 Trist catalog), we believe that Jefferson instead refers to his original 1783 manuscript catalog.

The manuscript catalog returned by Trist was, Jefferson writes, "precious to me." It is unlikely that a manuscript copy of a printed catalog Jefferson owned in triplicate would qualify as precious, however significant its arrangement.²² The 1783 catalog, on the other hand, was indeed precious, given its long tenure as Jefferson's primary reference tool and bibliophilic companion at Monticello; this catalog was the only remaining record of a cherished collection of books that Jefferson no longer owned. Equally suggestive, Trist observes to Jefferson in his letter of October 18 that he is returning "your catalogue" and worries apologetically that its "absence" had inconvenienced his soon-to-be grandfather-in-law.²³ The 1783 catalog, a working document for Jefferson's library at Monticello, would have been closely associated in Trist's mind with Jefferson himself (hence "your catalogue"), while the absence of a single copy of the 1815 printed catalog (which reproduced Watterston's alphabetical method of organization rather than Jefferson's own) would not have inconvenienced Jefferson.

We might follow Gilreath's and Wilson's line of reasoning and assume that Trist's "your catalogue" refers to a copy of the 1815 printed catalog that Jefferson annotated or "marked" for the purpose (and which, Gilreath and Wilson write, "is presumed lost"). However, records at the Library of Congress show that the 1823 Trist catalog has always been bound with the same copy of the 1815 printed catalog it is bound with today, one completely devoid of annotation. The surviving physical evidence in the binding of the unannotated 1815 catalog with the 1823 catalog strongly suggests that Trist did not use a "marked" copy of the 1815 printed catalog, but rather two catalogs: (1) Jefferson's separately

21. Gilreath and Wilson, *Thomas Jefferson's Library*, 6.

22. Jefferson's correspondence reveals that he owned at least three copies of the 1815 printed catalog. See his letter to George Watterston on March 2, 1816: "I received three copies of the Catalogue from mr Millegan for which I thank you" (*Founders Online*, National Archives, <https://founders.archives.gov/documents/Jefferson/03-09-02-0366>). One of these copies was bound with the blank leaves that would become the 1823 Trist catalog, a second was likely retained, and a third was sent to Joseph C. Cabell with a letter from Jefferson in which he complains about the 1815 catalog's alphabetical reorganization ("Thomas Jefferson to Joseph C. Cabell, 2 February 1816," *Founders Online*, National Archives, <https://founders.archives.gov/documents/Jefferson/03-09-02-0286>).

23. "Nicholas Philip Trist to Thomas Jefferson, 18 October 1823," *Founders Online*, National Archives, <https://founders.archives.gov/documents/Jefferson/98-01-02-3820>.

bound 1783 catalog, lent to Trist as a copy text; and (2) an unannotated copy of the 1815 printed catalog that was eventually bound with Trist's 1823 manuscript copy. Patterns of "foxing," or oxidized impurities on the final leaf of the 1823 Trist catalog have transferred to the facing title page of the 1815 printed catalog, and vice versa, suggesting that they were bound together early in their shared history. Tellingly, the text in the 1823 Trist catalog is occasionally trimmed away in the outer margin, demonstrating that it was bound after copying.²⁴ While we have not been able to locate a record of payment for the binding of these two documents in Jefferson's correspondence, memorandum books, or the Proctor's Papers at the University of Virginia, they have long been paired. While this is not proof that the copy of the 1815 printed catalog bound with 1823 catalog was the same copy Trist used in copying out his manuscript, the suggestive implications of the binding evidence and the resulting pairing of documents demand consideration.

More significant is the textual evidence that inheres in the catalogs themselves. Collating Jefferson's 1783 catalog and the 1823 Trist catalog suggests that the Trist manuscript could have derived from the 1783 catalog and an unmarked copy of the 1815 printed catalog alone. Textual and formal idiosyncrasies shared by the 1783 catalog, the 1815 printed catalog, and the 1823 Trist catalog suggests that the 1823 catalog derives from two sources, employing the "sometimes chronological, sometimes analytical" arrangement of the 1783 catalog but transcribing the content and descriptive form of the entries as they appear in the 1815 printed catalog. For instance, the 1823 catalog frequently replicates Jefferson's method of ordering entries in the 1783 catalog: the 1783 catalog's earliest entries were recorded on the verso of each leaf, so that later entries, rather than being interlined between existing entries, could be added to the facing recto at the appropriate point in Jefferson's sequence. The 1823 Trist manuscript seems to follow this order at various points, transcribing books listed across two pages in the 1783 catalog in a single sequence. When entries faced each other across the verso-recto opening of the 1783 catalog with no apparent priority, the verso entry on the left usually took precedence and was listed first (see figs. 2a and 2b; fig. 3 shows the corresponding section of the 1823 Trist manuscript). Meanwhile, Trist seems to have occasionally corrected ambiguities or discrepancies in the verso-recto ordering of the 1783 catalog by following the shelf mark numbers that accompany the corresponding entries in the 1815 printed catalog. For instance, Trist's decision to list 33. *Herodianus. Gr. Lat. Eng. 2 v. 12°* before 34. *Biographia Classica 2 v. 12°* in figure 3 was likely guided by the sequence of these shelf marks.

The 1783 catalog also contains annotations written in Jefferson's hand that seem to have guided Trist's enumerative work, particularly at points where the sequence of Jefferson's entries is unclear. These annotations did not reflect changes introduced by new acquisitions: Jefferson's verso-recto method of ordering entries limited the need for recopying, interlineation, and erasure when adding new titles

24. See 13 verso in Thomas Jefferson and Nicholas Philip Trist, "Catalogue" [1823], Manuscript/Mixed Material, <https://www.loc.gov/item/87204942/>.

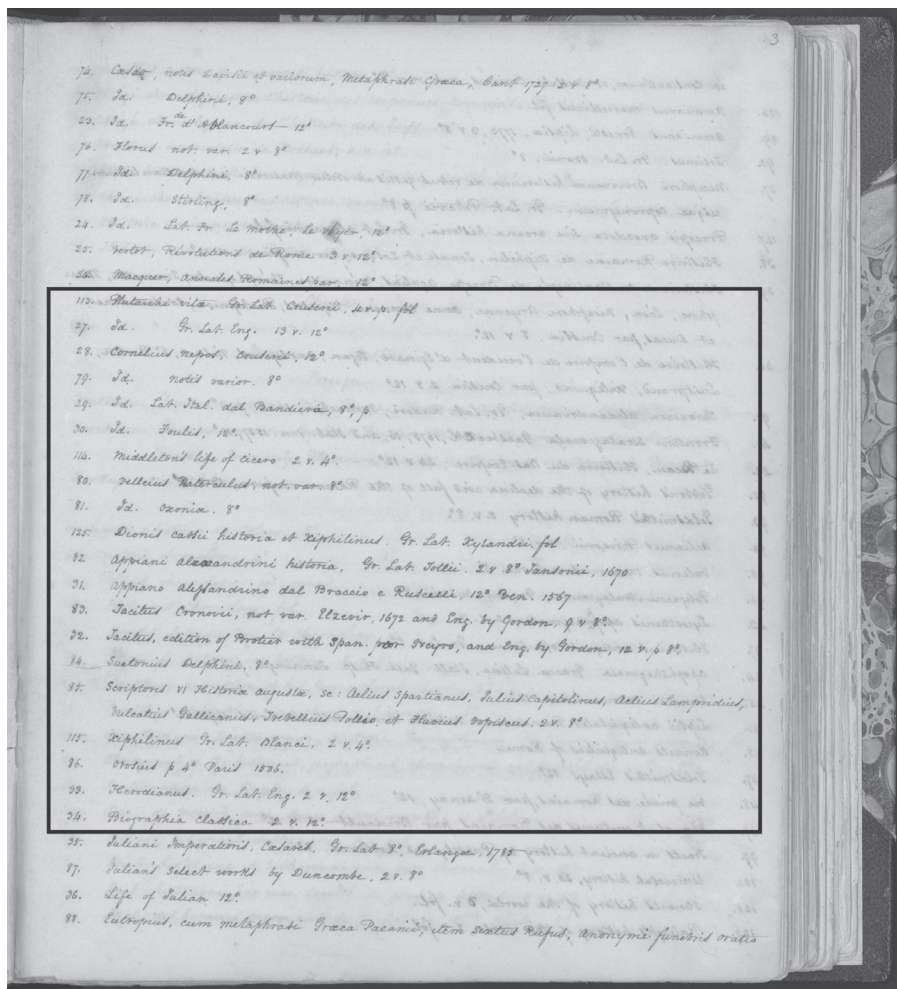


FIGURE 3. 1823 catalog, page 3, showing entries corresponding to those in figures 2a and 2b. The superimposed black frame encloses the entries that appear on the opening formed by pages 18 and 19 in the 1783 catalog. Image courtesy of the Thomas Jefferson Collection, Rare Book and Special Collections Division, The Library of Congress.

to the 1783 catalog.²⁵ Instead, this additional marginal numbering appears to have served an editorial purpose for an external reader—we believe for Trist. On the opening formed by pages 234 and 235 of the 1783 catalog, for instance, a series of

25. Jefferson occasionally marked the point at which a book was to be inserted by indexing titles on the facing recto with a siglum, usually letter, and adding a labelled arrow at the appropriate point on the verso (see, for example, pages 104 and 105 of the 1783 catalog).

numerals from 1 to 41 is faintly penciled in the left margins. These numerals, all in Jefferson's handwriting, assign a revised sequence to the books listed on these pages. Comparing the marginal numerals with the order of the corresponding entries in the Trist manuscript (found on 109 verso and 110 recto, Chapter 43, "Criticism, Languages") reveals that Trist followed this later sequence in copying entries from the 1815 printed catalog. Another example of Jefferson's marginal ordering guiding Trist's own comes in Chapter 20, "Law Merchant." In this brief chapter (comprising only ten titles), each entry in the 1783 catalog is accompanied by a numeral in the left margin, as above.²⁶ While the 1815 printed catalog arranges the ten entries in this chapter alphabetically by author, Trist's copy follows the order set out by Jefferson's annotations in the 1783 catalog (see figs. 4a-b and 5a-b).²⁷ In other words, while the entries in the 1823 Trist catalog follow the format, spelling, and syntax of those in the 1815 printed catalog (i.e., shelf number, author, title, volume count, format, date), they are arranged according to the sequence stipulated by these marginal ordinals found in the 1783 catalog.²⁸

In addition to these marginal numerals, the 1783 catalog contains discursive notes in Jefferson's handwriting, which may have served to augment or reiterate points made verbally to Trist during one of Trist's stays at Monticello.²⁹ These cryptic marginal and interlinear instructions are almost always expressed in brief imperatives, prescribing Jefferson's desired arrangement of entries in the 1783 catalog. One such note, on page 197 in Jefferson's Chapter 24 on "Politics," super-scribes a list of eighteen books. The note reads, "this should follow Brady of boroughs." Of these eighteen books, sixteen appear in the 1815 printed catalog. While Trist apparently failed to transcribe one of these sixteen—a copy of "Junius's letters, 2.v. 12mo"—the remaining fifteen titles appear in Trist's 1823 catalog after (as we might expect, and as Jefferson's note stipulated) "Brady on Boroughs."³⁰ We might assume, for the sake of argument, that Jefferson's instructions were meant to guide the arrangement of his lost 1812 catalog, a fair copy of the 1783 catalog.

26. An unnumbered eleventh title, "Cunningham's Law of bills, 8vo" was not listed in the 1815 printed catalog and so was not included by Trist in his 1823 manuscript copy.

27. Another series of marginal numbers in Jefferson's hand appears on page 155 of the 1783 catalog. These numbers order books listed in "Chapter 27, Geometry" according to a new sequence: Tacquet's Euclid precedes Stone's Euclid and Stone's Euclid precedes Simpson's. Eventually, at the bottom of the list, De Brahm's tract on leveling tools is labeled "21." Excepting the titles that do not appear in the 1815 catalog (and thus were not copied by Trist), Trist follows the order provided by these marginal numbers without deviation in preparing this section of the 1823 manuscript, again suggesting that Trist might have consulted these marginal annotations when arranging entries in his copy.

28. While Sowerby observed that changes in ordering made between the 1783 catalog and the 1812 fair copy "were not confined to the chapter arrangement, but apply also to the position of individual book entries," she did not speculate on the purpose behind Jefferson's revised ordering of the entries in some subject chapters. Instead, Sowerby silently amended the order of the entries to reflect Jefferson's annotations. See Sowerby, "Foreword," *Catalogue of the Library of Thomas Jefferson*, 4:8.

29. Trist and Jefferson's correspondence confirms that Trist was at Monticello in 1817, 1821, and 1823. It was likely during this final stay that Jefferson enlisted Trist's help on the University's library catalogs. See Heidi Hackford, "Nicholas Philip Trist," *Thomas Jefferson Encyclopedia*, <https://www.monticello.org/site/research-and-collections/nicholas-philip-trist>.

30. Jefferson and Trist, "Catalogue" [1823], 65 verso.

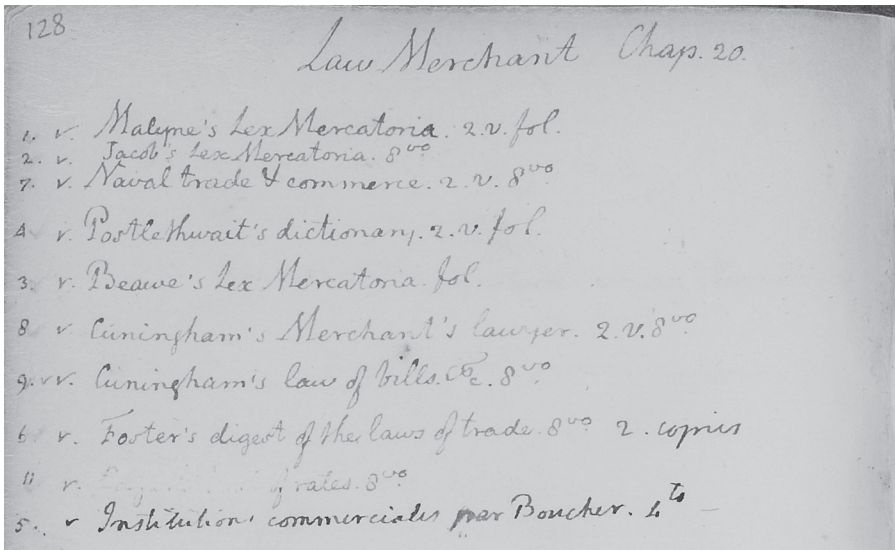


FIGURE 4A. 1783 catalog, page 128, showing the first entries in Chapter 20, "Law Merchant." Jefferson's added ordinal numbers, intended to guide Trist, appear in the left margin (here 1-9 and 11). Image courtesy of the Massachusetts Historical Society.

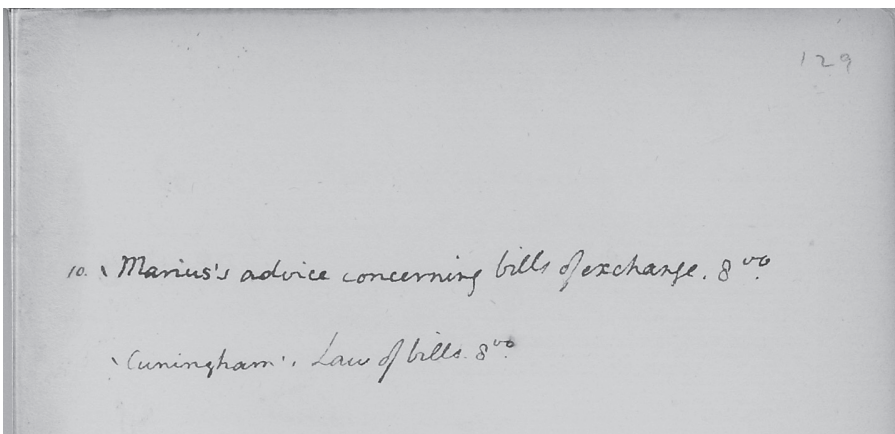


FIGURE 4B. 1783 catalog, page 129, showing more entries in Chapter 20, "Law Merchant." Jefferson's added ordinal numbers, possibly intended to guide Trist, appear in the left margin (here 10, with "Cuninghams Law of bills" unnumbered). Image courtesy of the Massachusetts Historical Society.

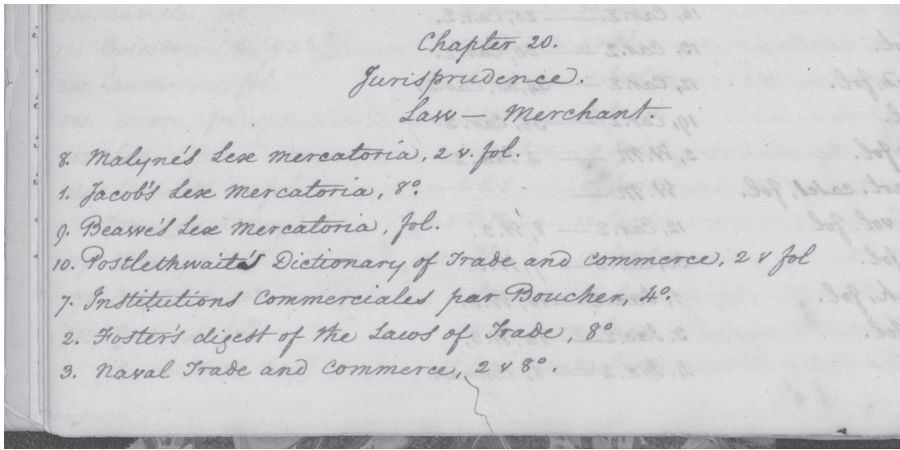


FIGURE 5A. 1823 Trist catalog, page 56, showing Trist's reordering of entries according to Jefferson's marginal numerals in the 1783 catalog (see figs. 4a, 4b). The marginal numbers next to Trist's entries are Jefferson's shelf mark numbers, copied from the 1815 printed catalog. Image courtesy of the Thomas Jefferson Collection, Rare Book and Special Collections Division, The Library of Congress.

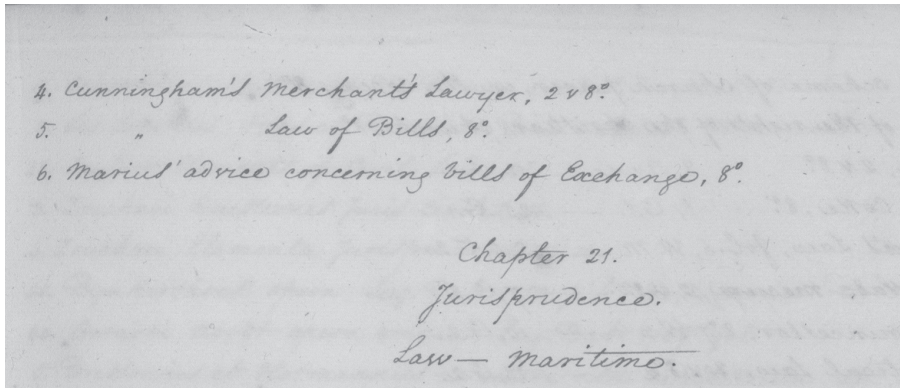


FIGURE 5B. 1823 Trist catalog, page 57, showing Trist's reordering of entries according to Jefferson's marginal numerals in the 1783 catalog (see figs. 4a, 4b). The marginal numbers next to Trist's entries are Jefferson's shelf mark numbers, copied from the 1815 printed catalog. Image courtesy of the Thomas Jefferson Collection, Rare Book and Special Collections Division, The Library of Congress.

This is certainly possible. Our argument, in contrast, assumes that these notes had another or subsequent audience, albeit an audience of one: Nicholas P. Trist.

Elsewhere in the 1783 catalog, Jefferson appended several notes regarding the patterns of arrangement that guided his "sometimes analytical, sometimes chronological" system and which Trist could have used as an interpretive model in copying entries from the 1815 printed catalog into his 1823 manuscript catalog.

In a note that appears on page 24, for instance, Jefferson bracketed off a section of books, writing "to be inserted between the history of Italy, Spain, Portugal, and France, and that of the northern nations of Europe." While a number of the titles in the bracketed section were excised (evidently rubbed out prior to Jefferson's annotation), Trist executed this marginal instruction in making up his copy: the bracketed books appear between the histories of southern and northern Europe, as specified. In a similar note on page 29A of the 1783 catalog, Jefferson wrote that books on southern European subjects were to be arranged in the following order, "General works, Italy, Rome, Florence, Naples, Venice, Spain, Portugal, France."³¹ Tellingly, Trist used this idiosyncratic geographical and national order throughout the 1823 catalog when applicable, with books on Italian subjects preceding titles on Spanish, Portuguese, and French subjects. A related note on page 31 of the 1783 catalog specifies the arrangement of books on Northern European and non-European cultures. This arrangement proceeds from "general works," to works on Lapland, Russia, Poland, Hungary, Sweden, Denmark, Prussia, Germany, Flanders, the Netherlands, Switzerland, Geneva, Turkey, Asia, and finally Africa. This typical, if sometimes variable, progression from south to north, from west to east, from general to particular, and from ancient to modern in Jefferson's historical chapters recurs in his literary and linguistic chapters and was often adopted by Trist seemingly by default. With basic verbal or written instructions from Jefferson, Trist would have been able to construct this geographical arrangement unaided. No marked copy text would have been required to produce Trist's 1823 entries that relate to these cultures, languages, or regions.

Unsurprisingly, there are many exceptions to the patterns and textual parallels we describe here. Most entries in the 1783 catalog lack Jefferson's clarifying ordinal numbers or marginal comments, for instance. In these cases, Trist could have departed from the verso-recto ordering of the 1783 catalog and instead employed the order provided by Jefferson's shelving numbers as they appear in the 1815 printed catalog.³² As Gilreath and Wilson note, "the initial number assigned to each entry [in the 1815 catalog] refers not to its catalog order but to its shelf position" on Jefferson's shelves.³³ Jefferson arranged books at Monticello by size, and each chapter of the 1815 printed catalog numbers entries accordingly by bibliographic format.³⁴ In a way, then, an unannotated copy of the 1815 printed catalog was already "annotated" with helpful ordinal guides. Trist could rely on

31. 1783 Catalog of Books, page 29A.

32. Watterston's catalog records the shelf marks that Jefferson's books bore upon arrival at the Library of Congress. Judging by Jefferson's 7 May 1815 letter to Watterston, the 1812 catalog also included shelving numbers: "on every book is a label, indicating the chapter of the catalogue to which it belongs, and the order it holds among those of the same format. so that, altho' the N^o seem confused on the catalogue, they are consecutive on the volumes as they stand on their shelves," "Thomas Jefferson to George Watterston, 7 May 1815," *Founders Online*, National Archives, <https://founders.archives.gov/documents/Jefferson/03-08-02-0376>.

33. Gilreath and Wilson, *Thomas Jefferson's Library*, 7.

34. These shelving numbers, which precede each entry in the 1815 printed catalog and are copied out by Trist in Trist's 1823 manuscript, were devised and affixed to Jefferson's books during the production of the 1812 fair copy. The 1783 catalog only loosely reflects the order of Jefferson's shelves and none of the 1783 entries include shelf marks or numbers.

these printed shelving numbers to reconstruct Jefferson's preferred order of books when other forms of guidance (e.g., Jefferson's marginal numbering) were lacking.

Jefferson's subject chapter on "Chemistry" shows how Trist might have occasionally relied on shelving numbers printed in the 1815 catalog when ordering the entries in his 1823 manuscript copy. In this chapter, the numbered series runs as follows: numbers 1-6 are duodecimos, numbers 7-29 are octavos, and number 30 is a quarto. In copying the thirty titles that appear in this chapter from the 1815 printed catalog, Trist first transcribed the entries for the chapter's first (and only) quarto ("30. Neumann's chemistry, by Lewis"), its first octavo ("7. McQueer's chemistry"), and the chapter's first duodecimo ("1. Dictionnaire de Chimie de Macquers"). In this case, Trist roughly followed the order of the 1783 catalog, which lists these three titles at the head of the chapter, likely due to their generalizing treatment of the subject. Following these three titles, however—perhaps due to the ambiguous arrangement of the remaining books in this chapter in the 1783 catalog and the absence of Jefferson's ordinal annotations—Trist deferred to the shelf marks in the 1815 printed catalog to order the entries in his 1823 copy (fig. 6). The sole exception—the appearance of a duodecimo, "6. Jacob's Chemical pocket companion," among an uninterrupted sequence of octavos—is likely the result of Trist returning to the order of the 1783 catalog, which collocates "Jacob's chemical pocket companion" and "Jacob's experiments on Urinary and Intestinal Calculi" (an octavo).³⁵ This method of reordering books according to the sequence of Jeffer-

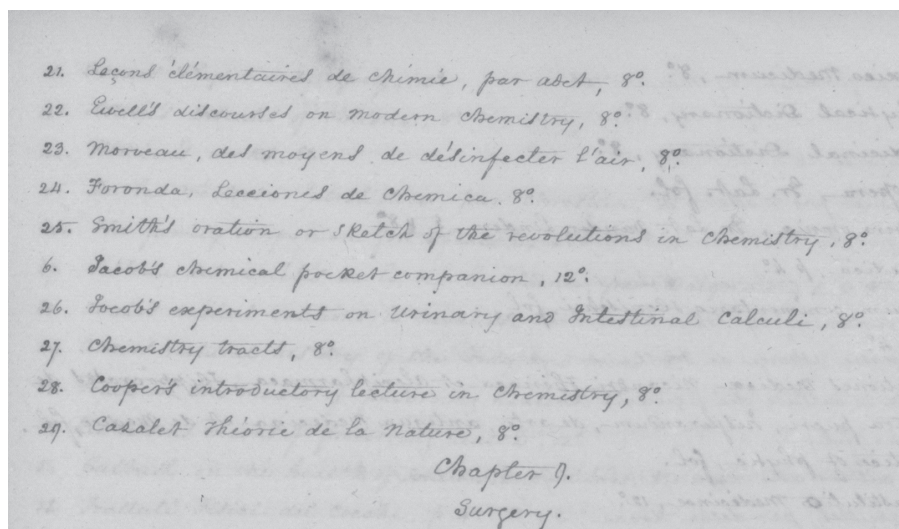


FIGURE 6. 1823 Trist catalog, page 23, showing entries in Chapter 8, "Chemistry," arranged according to Jefferson's shelf mark numbers (here, 21-25, 6, and 26-29). Image courtesy of the Thomas Jefferson Collection, Rare Book and Special Collections Division, The Library of Congress.

35. See 1783 Catalog, page 61.

son's shelving numbers recurs across the 1823 Trist catalog, and for good reason: if a sequence of titles of the same format was ambiguous in the 1783 catalog, Trist no doubt knew that transcribing them in the order in which they were shelved would (in most cases) preserve Jefferson's chronological-analytical arrangement.

While the examples detailed here do not fully account for the similarities and points of divergence between the 1783 catalog and Trist's copy, they reveal much about how and why Jefferson enlisted Trist to compile the 1823 catalog. Not only do these notes and markings demonstrate that Jefferson undertook a final, belated revision of the 1783 catalog (most excisions, annotations, and additions dating from this period appear in slightly darker ink or pencil), they also show an apparent and complex dialogue between the 1823 Trist manuscript and the 1783 catalog. This is a crucial point: it was a dialogue, and the 1823 Trist manuscript could have been produced by means of collation. This, we admit, is a radical argument, given that it removes some agency from Jefferson and grants agency to Trist. But to suggest that Trist played a sizable role in interpreting and converting the arrangement of Jefferson's scheme as represented in the 1783 catalog in compiling his 1823 manuscript is far from baseless: during this period Jefferson was occupied with a variety of projects concerning the foundation of the university and himself acknowledged that his skill for library classification and recondite questions of epistemology had atrophied with time: in a letter sent to Augustus Elias Brevoort on 24 March 1824 Jefferson described changes he'd prefer to make to his original system of arranging books but concludes by remarking, "these are speculations in which I do not now permit myself to labour. [M]y mind unwillingly engages in severe investigations. [I]t's energies indeed are no longer equal to them."³⁶

If Jefferson's notes in the 1783 catalog were not intended for Trist, for whom were they penned? While Jefferson may have intended them as notes to himself, perhaps to guide the completion of his lost 1812 fair copy, the consistency with which these instructions are executed in the 1823 Trist catalog suggests that they were written to aid Trist, with some of the arrangement left to Trist's informed discretion. Another possibility, potentially coexistent, is that Trist had written instructions from Jefferson in some form other than an annotated copy of the 1815 printed catalog. These might have taken the form of a list of rules elaborating Jefferson's "chronological-analytical" system, or notes that would have prescribed, at least in outline, how the entries in the 1815 printed catalog were to be reordered.

Our interpretation of the evidence, rather than disproving or refuting Wilson and Gilreath's argument, simply offers an alternative account that relies less on Jefferson's direct involvement, more on Trist's informed resourcefulness, and notably does not require the existence of a methodically annotated copy of the 1815 printed catalog. This last point raises the crucial question: if such a copy text did exist, with ordinal numbers next to each entry in the 1815 printed catalog, why would Jefferson require Trist's assistance? The task would have been reduced to mere copying, something that could be done relatively quickly and by anyone in Jefferson's household possessing an abundance of patience and an even hand.

36. "From Thomas Jefferson to Augustus Elias Brevoort Woodward, 24 March 1824," *Founders Online*, National Archives, <https://founders.archives.gov/documents/Jefferson/98-01-02-4139>. [This is an *Early Access* document from *The Papers of Thomas Jefferson: Retirement Series*. It is not an authoritative final version.]

The epistolary record shows that Jefferson's granddaughters worked regularly as his amanuenses in 1823 and 1824. But Trist was enlisted instead; and the project, far from requiring days or weeks, was completed apparently over several months, after Trist had left Monticello and taken his copy texts with him. The timeline, as well as Jefferson's apologetic response to Trist seeking pardon for "the difficulty" of the task, conspire to suggest that the textual history of the 1823 Trist catalog is more complex than Gilreath and Wilson's account allows. It might be suggested that Jefferson was here referring to the "difficulty" of Trist's writing out the 114 pages of the 1823 catalog, but that ignores an alternate reading of Jefferson's letter: the "difficulty" to which Jefferson "subjected" Trist was that of disentangling his system of organization with recourse only to the 1783 catalog, its sporadic notes and marginal instructions, and an unannotated 1815 printed catalog.

After recounting the evidence, our theory can now be laid out in full: our account of the copy text(s) of the 1823 Trist catalog renders an annotated 1815 catalog unnecessary. We might go even further: with only the 1783 catalog (and its notes) and a copy of the 1815 catalog to hand, anyone well versed in Jefferson's shelving schema and his epistemological habits of thought could produce a document nearly equivalent in form and makeup to the Trist manuscript, though with occasional variants resulting from ambiguities in the arrangement of entries in the 1783 catalog. In Trist's case, with the written instructions from Jefferson in the 1783 catalog and some verbal preparation—likely imparted while Trist was at Monticello after June 1821, or when he began studying law with Jefferson at Monticello in spring of 1823—Jefferson's desired order could have been reconstructed.³⁷ Where ambiguities arose or when a revised order was required, Jefferson's marginal instructions in the 1783 catalog guided Trist's work; or alternatively, Trist could fall back on his own knowledge of Jefferson's "sometimes chronological, sometimes analytical" arrangement or the order of Jefferson's shelving, as recorded in the shelf mark numbers printed in the 1815 printed catalog.

Having introduced the first four catalogs relevant to our argument—the 1783 catalog, the 1812 fair copy, the 1815 printed catalog, and the 1823 Trist catalog—we advance the pattern of filiation illustrated in the stemma in figure 7. This stemma, and the bibliographical evidence enumerated above offer a new textual account of the 1823 catalog, but leaves the reason for its production obscure: what was its purpose and the uses to which it was put? Why would Jefferson want Trist to laboriously compile an eclectic catalog, reproducing the contents of the 1815 printed catalog and the arrangement of the annotated 1783 catalog, as late as 1823? Was it because Jefferson simply hoped to recover the extent and arrangement of his library before its sale to Congress in 1812? Or was it because Jefferson was engaged in the most significant and demanding project he undertook in retirement: the formation and planning of the University of Virginia and its library? Douglas Wilson allowed this point in his article announcing the rediscovery of the 1823 catalog.³⁸ Similarly, Endrina Tay has linked the 1823 Trist catalog to Jefferson's plan for the university's library, noting that Trist's copy was made "so that [Jefferson] would have on hand a reference list of the books in his previous library ordered by subject as he began to plan the library collection for

37. See Hackford, "Nicholas Philip Trist."

38. Wilson, "Sowerby Revisited," 624. Quoted above.

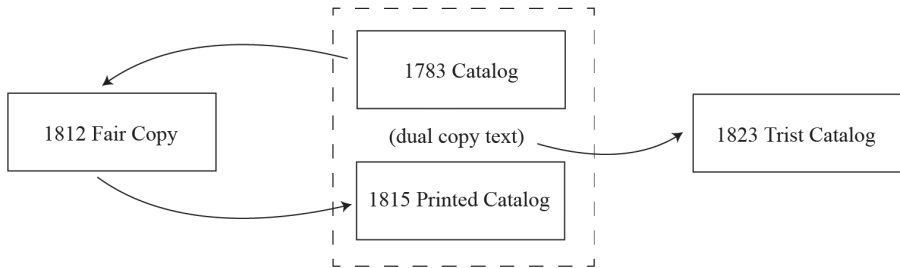


FIGURE 7. We have so far suggested that the 1823 Trist catalog is an eclectic text, copied from Jefferson's annotated 1783 catalog and an unannotated copy of the 1815 printed catalog.

the University of Virginia.”³⁹ In the second half of this study, we present textual evidence that speaks to the question. More precisely, by examining three manuscript booklists associated with the University of Virginia's first library, we show that all three are textually related to Trist's 1823 catalog.

THE “LOST” 1824 CATALOG

In September 1824, Francis Walker Gilmer, a young Virginian lawyer, ordered 509 books for the University of Virginia from London bookseller John Henry Martin Bohn (1757–1843).⁴⁰ The Board of Visitors had sent Gilmer to England to recruit the University's first professors and to buy books “deemed indispensable for a beginning.”⁴¹ But how did Gilmer know which books to buy? Although Jefferson had Trist's 1823 catalog on hand several months before Gilmer's departure, there is no evidence to suggest that Jefferson or the Board supplied

39. Tay, “Forming the Body of a Library,” 221 n32.

40. On Bohn, see David Pearson, *Provenance Research in Book History: A Handbook* (Oxford: The Bodleian Library, 2019), 198–199. Nearing the end of his time in London, Gilmer wrote to Jefferson to report that he had contracted with Bohn to supply the university's first books, noting that he had “made out a catalogue of such as we must have, and have ordered the books & instruments, to be shipped as soon as possible” (“Francis Walker Gilmer to Thomas Jefferson, 15 September 1824,” *Founders Online*, National Archives, <https://founders.archives.gov/documents/Jefferson/98-01-02-4545>). For an account of Gilmer's time abroad, see Thomas Jefferson, Francis Walker Gilmer, and Richard Beale Davis, *Correspondence of Thomas Jefferson and Francis Walker Gilmer, 1814–1826* (Columbia: University of South Carolina Press, 1946). The figure of 509 books is based on an examination of Bohn's invoices, some of which survive in the Albert & Shirley Small Special Collections Library at the University of Virginia (UVA MSS 11848, 11902). This figure is also based on an examination of the earliest holdings catalog in use at the University of Virginia—the so-called John Vaughn Kean catalog, discussed below—which lists the first books to arrive.

41. The Board had granted Gilmer a budget of 6,000 dollars to purchase “such chemical, astronomical, physical, and mathematical apparatus, and ... such text-books, as on consultation with the respective professors, each for his department, shall be deemed indispensable for a beginning” (University of Virginia Board of Visitors, Minute Book [1817–1828], 58; RG-1/1/1.381, Special Collections, University of Virginia Library, Charlottesville, Va). A list of books supplied to Gilmer by the University's first professor of mathematics, Thomas Hewitt Key, and a list of Hebrew books, evidently supplied by the University's first professor of Ancient Languages, George Long, survive in the Albert and Shirley Small Special Collections Library at the University of Virginia (UVA MSS 106).

Gilmer with Trist's manuscript or a similarly comprehensive list of books to be procured in London. Instead, it seems they stipulated little and left much to Gilmer's discretion.⁴² Gilmer's acquisition of the university's first books should not suggest that the university's library was formed without Jefferson's direction. Far from it; surviving correspondence reveals that while Gilmer was shopping in London's book-selling districts, Jefferson was at work on yet another list of books, this one meant to be a full and final enumeration of the university's inchoate and still largely theoretical library. This **1824 catalog** was aspirational rather than descriptive, insofar as it listed books Jefferson hoped the university would acquire to fill the Rotunda's yet-unbuilt shelves. It was, in other words, a list of desiderata—a list of books to buy, rather than books already obtained.

It had been long assumed that this Jeffersonian 1824 catalog was lost in a fire that gutted the University of Virginia's Rotunda and destroyed many of its books in October 1895.⁴³ However, a leaf apparently removed from the 1824 catalog's front matter was recently rediscovered in the Rare Book Division of the Library of Congress.⁴⁴ This rediscovered leaf shows that Jefferson's 1824 catalog and the books it enumerates were divided into 42 subject classifications, a modified version of Jefferson's schema used to arrange his books at Monticello (see fig. 8). Jefferson's correspondence indicates that he enlisted the help of friends and acquaintances in supplementing subject classifications that treated disciplines unfamiliar to him. Yet as the catalog's unique subject categories show, the bulk of the 1824 catalog was likely Jefferson's work alone. In a letter to James Madison written on August 8, 1824, Jefferson reports beginning his new list: "I have undertaken to make out a catalogue of books for our library, being encouraged to it by the possession of a collection of excellent catalogues, and knowing no one, capable, to whom we could refer the task."⁴⁵ This "collection of excellent catalogues" presumably

42. The possibility that Gilmer took the 1823 Trist catalog (completed in October, 1823, and received by Jefferson in time to be advanced to Gilmer before his departure for London) or a copy of the 1815 printed catalog is easily disproved: of the 509 known titles shipped to the University by Bohn, only a few are listed in the 1815 printed catalog (and thus in the Trist 1823 catalog). In many cases, Gilmer's stamp on the collection is clear; for instance, Gilmer ordered a near complete set of Leonard Euler's works on optics and mechanics—ten titles in all—none of which Jefferson had owned, and none of which are listed in Trist's 1823 manuscript. If the 1823 Trist catalog had served as an enumerative desiderata in ordering books from Bohn, there is little evidence for it.

43. This "lost" catalog was first described by University librarian Frederick Winslow Page in an article published in September, 1895—a month before the fire. In this article, Page characterized the catalog as "a manuscript volume, without date, but evidently prepared by [Jefferson] between the years 1820 and 1825, which [Jefferson] styles 'A Catalogue of Books Forming the Body of a Library for the University of Virginia,' prefaced by an explanation of the views on which it is based, and by his classification into forty-two chapters, embracing 6,860 volumes." See F. W. Page, "Our Library," *The Alumni Bulletin of the University of Virginia* 2, no. 2 (1895): 78-85.

44. Mark Dimunation, Chief of the Rare Book and Special Collections Division at the Library of Congress, brought the leaf to our attention. The leaf is wove paper (verso blank) and measures 132 x 168 mm. For a full description and analysis, see Samuel V. Lemley and Neal D. Curtis, "A Catalogue of Books in Thomas Jefferson's Hand: A Leaf from a Manuscript Presumed Lost," *Notes & Queries* 264, no. 1 (2019): 130-35.

45. "Thomas Jefferson to James Madison, 8 August 1824," *Founders Online*, National Archives, <https://founders.archives.gov/documents/Jefferson/98-01-02-4445>.

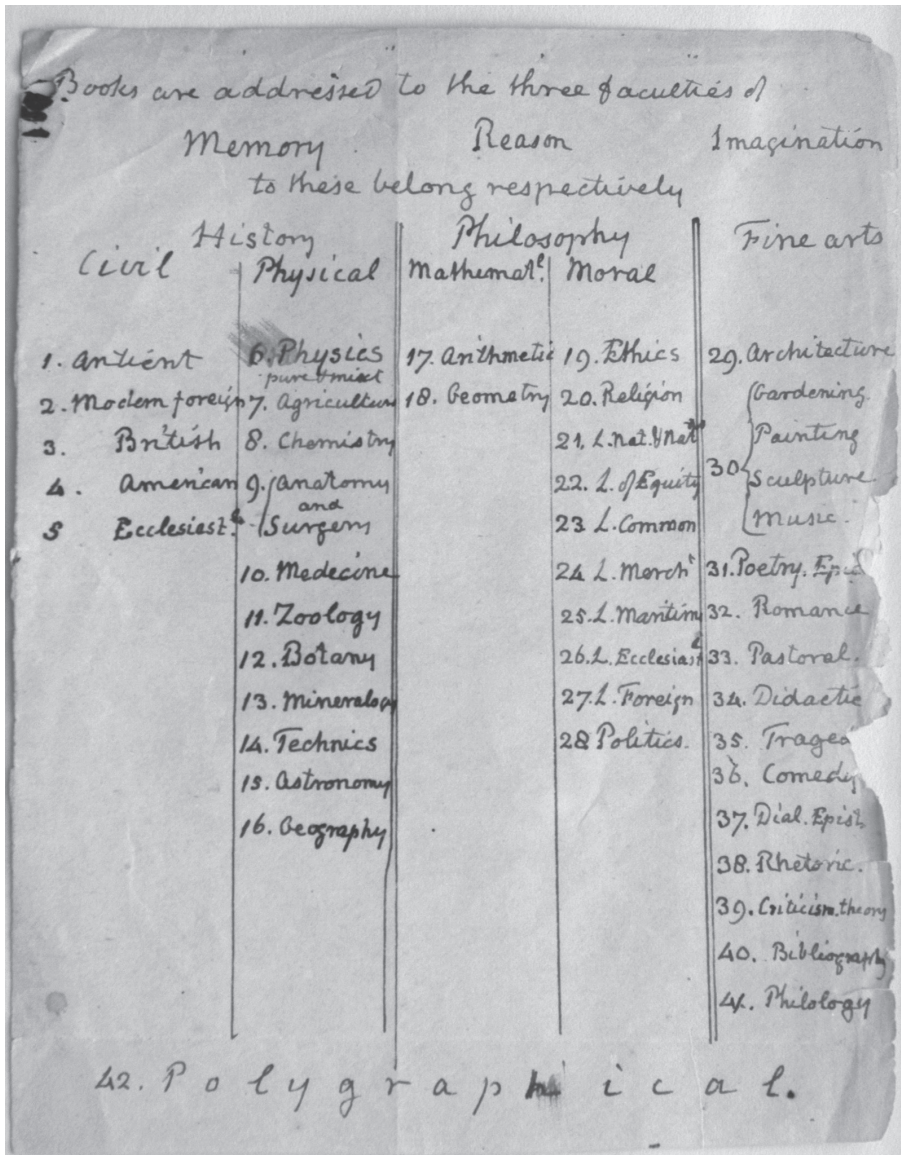


FIGURE 8. The rediscovered leaf, presumably excised from Jefferson's 1824 catalog. The manuscript has not yet been cataloged. Image courtesy of the Rare Book and Special Collections Division, Library of Congress.

included booksellers' catalogs Jefferson had acquired in the past or recently solicited, but his preferences and experience in forming libraries over the course of his life would also have exerted a governing influence; Jefferson's existing library catalogs were his likeliest and most reliable source in creating the 1824 catalog. Indeed, a catalog of the University of Virginia's library printed in 1828 (that is, after Jefferson's death and after most of the books listed in the lost 1824 catalog had been ordered, delivered, and installed in the Rotunda) lists a collection of just over 3,400 titles in 8,000 volumes.⁴⁶ Of these titles, a majority are listed in the 1823 Trist catalog—the catalog most recently commissioned by Jefferson when he began his desiderata list in 1824.

The simplest explanation for this coincidence of entries is that Jefferson employed the 1823 Trist catalog as a base-text in compiling the 1824 catalog. And as such, the 1823 Trist catalog was not an attempt at reconstituting Jefferson's "lost" ordering of his books; or at least not only. While it *did* reorder the entries in the 1815 printed catalog according to Jefferson's "chronological-analytical" arrangement, it also provided a baseline enumeration of the titles and editions intended to fill the Rotunda's shelves. In the next section, we examine two catalogs subsequent to Jefferson's 1824 desiderata to show that the evidence for a filiation linking the 1823 Trist catalog and the lost 1824 catalog is textual, rather than merely circumstantial. We contend that the 1823 Trist catalog was the textual foundation of the University of Virginia's first library and was compiled and commissioned with the impending creation of the 1824 catalog in mind.⁴⁷ More precisely, we suggest that the primary purpose of Trist's 1823 catalog was one of expedience. In planning the university's library, Jefferson required a full and clear record of his own library at its greatest extent—that is, immediately before it was sold to Congress in 1814—but arranged in a manner that was familiar to him.

46. The University of Virginia Library published a facsimile reproduction of this catalog in 1945. See University of Virginia Library and William Peden, *1828 Catalogue of the Library of the University of Virginia: Reproduced in Facsimile with an Introduction by William Harwood Peden*, University of Virginia Bibliographical Series (Charlottesville: Printed for the Alderman Library of the University of Virginia, 1945).

47. While Jefferson's so-called "retirement library" catalog may have served as another copy text, the extent and topical range of Jefferson's 1783 catalog was a better model for the University of Virginia's first library. In contrast, Jefferson viewed the retirement library as "a collection for my self of such as may amuse my hours of reading" (Thomas Jefferson to David Bailie Warden, 27 February 1815, polygraph copy in Thomas Jefferson Papers, Library of Congress, <https://www.loc.gov/item/mtjbibo21010/>). The retirement library also comprised only 1600 volumes, many of which also appear in the 1783 catalog. We exclude the retirement catalog from our stemma, as it is textually unrelated to the seven catalogs and lists we examine here. The books that formed this "retirement" library were, however, willed to the University after Jefferson's death. In advance of the transfer of these books to the University, titles that were already held in the Rotunda were marked with an "L" in Jefferson's retirement catalog. These were presumably withheld from the bequest to avoid duplication on the Rotunda's shelves. The Thomas Jefferson's Libraries project has published a detailed account of the retirement catalog's origins and compilation. See "Retirement Library Catalogue," *Thomas Jefferson's Libraries*, <http://tjlibraries.monticello.org/tjandreading/retirement.html>.

THE 1825 JOHN VAUGHN KEAN CATALOG & JEFFERSON'S
LAST BOOKLIST: THE UNIVERSITY OF VIRGINIA'S
FIRST BOOKS ARRIVE IN CHARLOTTESVILLE

As Gilmer's order of books began to arrive in crates from London and Europe, a catalog was required to make the new library useful to students and faculty in the fledgling university.⁴⁸ This first catalog, extant in the Albert & Shirley Small Special Collections Library at UVA, is what is known as a holdings catalog, in that it describes a collection of books on shelves, in contrast to the aspirational list Jefferson was then at work compiling. It is a small manuscript booklet prepared by the university's first librarian, a recently enrolled undergraduate named John Vaughn Kean.⁴⁹ Inscribed on the catalog's improvised title page is "May 16th 1825," presumably the day on which Kean finished the catalog.⁵⁰

Kean's catalog is the product of a meticulous amateur. It is crudely bound with multiple gatherings chain-stitched together and covered in gray pulp paper. On the recto of its first leaf, Kean inscribed a provisional title—"A catalog of the Library of the University of Va."—and below this, added his name three times in a flourishing script. Despite the homespun quality of Kean's catalog, its front-matter demonstrates a working familiarity with Jefferson's bibliographical habits and system of library organization. For example, after providing an itemized account of the library's holdings by format ("168 folios, 388 4tos, 1609 8vos ...") Kean drew a table of classifications comprising 42 subject chapters (fig. 9). The graphical layout of this table is identical to the one that appears on the rediscovered leaf of Jefferson's 1824 catalog (noted above; also see fig. 8), indicating that Kean had Jefferson's catalog on hand while preparing his own. This is supported by Jefferson's brief correspondence with Kean. In a letter sent to Jefferson on 22 April 1825, Kean remarked that he was returning a catalog to Jefferson: "I have sent the catalogue, which you have been so kind as to make for me." There is little doubt that Kean is here referring to the lost 1824 catalog, or a copy of it.

48. These first books are described in Rotunda Library Online (RLO), <http://www.rotundalibrary.online>, a bibliographical database and short title catalog that lists every book shelved in the University of Virginia's first library. Filter results by "Provenance: John Bohn (London)." The absence of a catalog for these first books was a serious concern. Writing to the University's first librarian, John Vaughn Kean, Jefferson explained that a library "in confusion loses much of it's utility" ("Thomas Jefferson to John V. Kean, 16 May 1825," *Founders Online*, National Archives, <https://founders.archives.gov/documents/Jefferson/98-01-02-5229>). In an earlier letter charging Kean with his duties as the university's librarian, Jefferson noted that Kean would be expected to "keep the books ... in their stated arrangement on the shelves according to the method and order of their Catalogue" ("Thomas Jefferson to John V. Kean, 30 March 1825," *Founders Online*, National Archives, <https://founders.archives.gov/documents/Jefferson/98-01-02-5092>).

49. John Vaughn Kean was the son of Dr. Andrew Kean, who served at various points as Jefferson's personal physician. The younger Kean was appointed to the post of Librarian by Jefferson on 30 March, 1825 ("Thomas Jefferson to John V. Kean, 30 March 1825," *Founders Online*, National Archives, <https://founders.archives.gov/documents/Jefferson/98-01-02-5092>).

50. The Rotunda would not open for another 19 months, in October 1826. The first books to arrive at the University of Virginia were shelved in Pavilion Seven, a structure embedded in the western arm or "dependency" of the University's Jeffersonian lawn.

1. Books are addressed to the three faculties of
 Memory Reason Imagination
 To these belong respectively

History	Philosophy	Fine Arts
Civil	Mathematical	20 Architecture
1. ancient	17 Arithmetic	(Gardening
2. Modern foreign	18 Geometry	30 Religion
3. British		21 L. Nature & Nat.
4. American		22 L. Equity
5 Ecclesiastic		23 L. Common
		24 L. Merchant
		25 L. Maritime
		26 L. Ecclesiastic
		27 L. Foreign
		28 Civil Policy
		37 Dial. Epistles
		38 Rhetoric
		39 Criticism Theory
		40 Bibliography
		41 Philology

42. Poly-graphical

FIGURE 9. John Vaughn Kean's methodical copy of the subject schema drawn out by Jefferson on the rediscovered leaf at the Library of Congress (fig. 8). Image courtesy of the Albert and Shirley Small Special Collections Library, University of Virginia. RG.12/12/1.161.

Jefferson's earlier catalogs—including the 1783 catalog and his "retirement library" catalog (see footnote 48)—arrange their respective schemata in a dendritic, horizontal pattern that forms a series of interlinked and branching lines that terminate in the names of individual subject chapters (fig. 10). Kean's catalog, by contrast, follows the unique columnar format found on the rediscovered leaf of the 1824 catalog with no apparent deviation. However, the most striking visual resemblance between Kean's diagram and Jefferson's 1824 original is the position and appearance of the final subject chapter's title, "42. Polygraphical." This chapter, which Jefferson devised to contain books that address all or several intellectual "faculties promiscuously," held books on hybrid or various subjects.⁵¹ Because of its varied makeup, this final chapter is classed across all three of Jefferson's Baconian faculties, involving "Reason," "Memory," and "Imagination." In both Kean's copy and on the rediscovered leaf of Jefferson's 1824 catalog, this chapter stretches across the tables' five columns, indicating its variety of subjects, languages, and disciplines. Similarly, both Kean's diagram and Jefferson's 1824 table assign the name "Technics" to chapter 14, a subject classification which Jefferson elsewhere termed "Technical Arts."⁵² While Jefferson's so-called retirement library also assigned the name "Technics" to its eighth subject chapter, the retirement library comprised fewer chapters (33), and never employed the 42-chapter, columnar schema in use at the University of Virginia and represented in Kean's 1825 catalog and on the rediscovered 1824 leaf.⁵³

Jefferson's 1824 catalog and its 42-chapter table of subject classifications thus offered Kean a model in preparing his own catalog. Whether Kean was solely responsible for arranging the university's first books in these 42 chapters is doubtful, however; it is more likely that Jefferson somehow indicated their place in Kean's list by marking their respective classifications in the 1824 catalog before sending it to Kean, or by annotating another list that no longer survives.⁵⁴ Without such a guide, the chronological-analytical way in which Jefferson ordered books within the chapters of the 1824 catalog would have been inscrutable to Kean, who (unlike Trist) was unversed in Jefferson's system. It is safe to assume, then, that the catalog "made for" Kean and referenced in Kean's 22 April letter provided some welcome guidance—much like, for instance, Jefferson's annota-

51. *Volume 7: Jefferson's Second Library*, 1829, Manuscript / Mixed Material, Library of Congress; leaf 2 recto. <https://www.loc.gov/item/mtjbibo26579/>.

52. In the 1783 catalog and the 1815 printed catalog, this subject appears as "Technical Arts" and is assigned to Chapter 15.

53. A manuscript diagram of the schema used by Jefferson to organize his retirement library survives at the Library of Congress: *Volume 7: Jefferson's Second Library* (see note 52). The revised terminology (from "Technical Arts" to "Technics") is also evidence of the LoC leaf's late composition, as Jefferson apparently only began to use the term "Technics" in retirement and after the sale of his Monticello library to Congress in 1815.

54. It is probable that Jefferson added entries for books ordered by Gilmer to the 1824 catalog after receiving Gilmer's invoices or report. While the 1824 catalog mainly listed books that were on order and not yet received, it would in time become a complete record of the University's library. Presumably, Gilmer had ordered books that Jefferson never owned, and therefore were not listed in the 1823 Trist catalog that formed the basis of the lost 1824 catalog. Kean could have consulted these added entries, arranged in their appointed subject chapters, in determining how to shelve and classify books shipped from Bohn. While some itemized invoices from Bohn, apparently incomplete, survive in the Albert & Shirley Small Special Collections Library (MSS 11902), no full enumeration of Gilmer's order placed with Bohn survives.

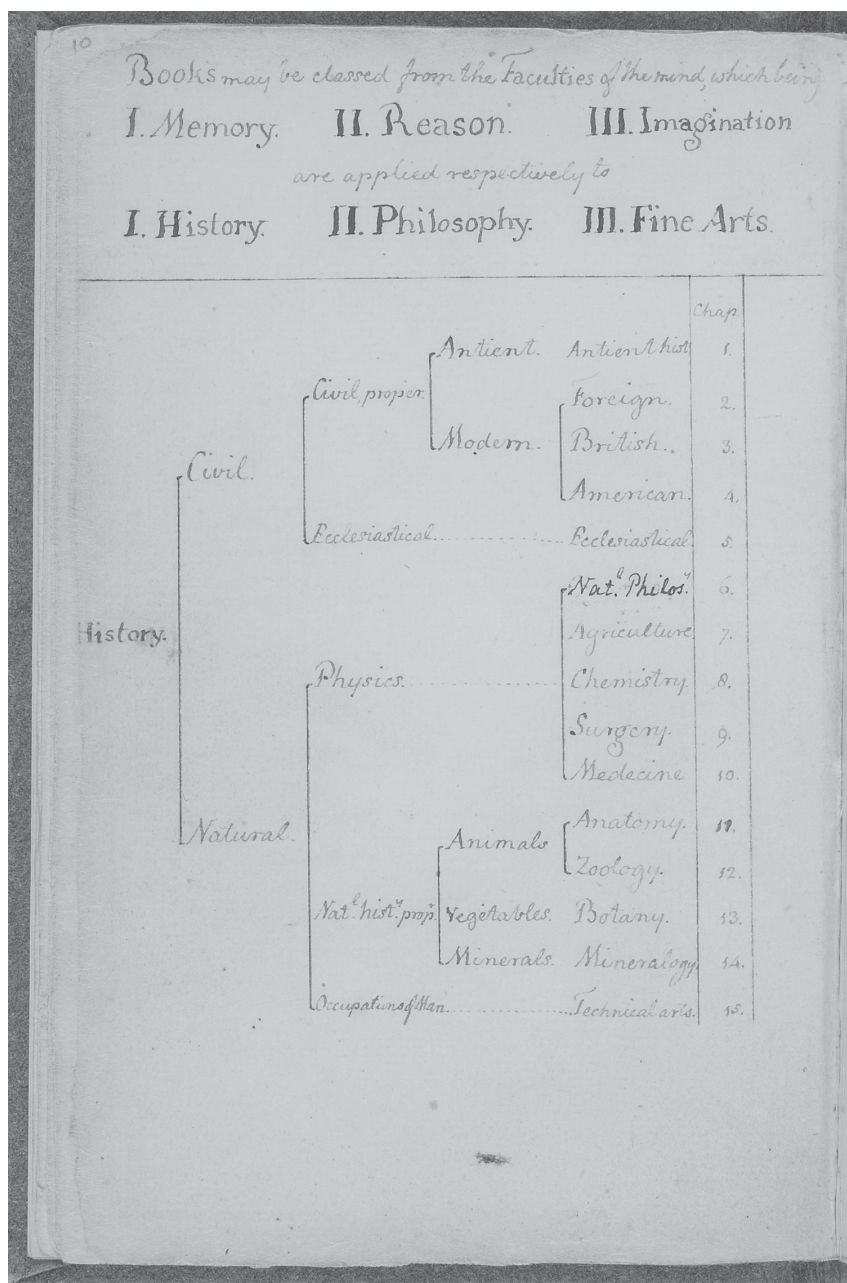


FIGURE 10. An example of Jefferson's dendriform classification table from the 1783 catalog (page 10), with each "branch" terminating in an individual subject chapter (see figs. 8 and 9). Image courtesy of the Massachusetts Historical Society.

tions to the 1783 catalog had done for Trist. (In a June 19, 1825 letter, Kean goes so far as to invite Jefferson's help arranging the university's first books in their subject classes. Kean adds that "Dr. Blaetterman has commenced & will complete it," if Jefferson is unable to do the arranging himself.⁵⁵) Ultimately, though, the question of who was responsible for categorizing the university's books into the 42 chapters of Kean's catalog is immaterial. Comparing the rediscovered leaf of the 1824 catalog and Kean's carefully copied table of classifications makes clear that Kean's catalog derived from Jefferson's lost 1824 catalog.

The occasion for creating the 1825 Kean catalog has already been stated: with Jefferson's lost 1824 catalog to guide him, Kean listed the books that made up Gilmer's order from Bohn and arranged them in their appointed places according to the 42-chapter system devised by Jefferson—a task completed presumably when Kean dated the catalog's cover on 16 May 1825.⁵⁶ But Kean's catalog had another purpose besides. As Jefferson finished work on his 1824 desiderata—copying from the 1823 Trist catalog and consulting his correspondence with friends, his retirement library catalog, and his collection of booksellers' lists—he encountered a problem that only Kean and his catalog could solve. Because Gilmer had acquired most of the university's first books without consulting any of Jefferson's evolving booklists, Jefferson needed to ensure that duplicate titles weren't ordered from the university's newly appointed bookseller, Cummings & Hilliard of Boston.⁵⁷ In other words, Jefferson needed Kean's catalog to determine which books in the 1824 catalog had been ordered and would need to be omitted from a final list.

Jefferson had reason to hurry. By July 14, 1824, William Hilliard had written offering to "supply your University with such Books as may be wanted for Your course of studies."⁵⁸ Jefferson replied on September 6, 1824, expressing his interest

55. Thomas Jefferson from John V. Kean, 19 June 1825, *Founders Online*, National Archives, <https://founders.archives.gov/documents/Jefferson/98-01-02-5310>. This later shipment of books was part of a subsequent order of books placed with Boston booksellers, Cummings & Hilliard, described below.

56. In a January 20, 1825, letter to Gilmer, Jefferson remarks, "Our books &c (8. boxes) are arrived. I have had the covers of the boxes taken off to admit dry air, but we cannot take them out for want of the catalogue; because if we do not assort them under their proper heads of arrangement when first taken out, it would be infinitely difficult afterwards. will you be so good as to send me the catalogue by return of mail, for I think they are suffering from damp" ("Thomas Jefferson to Francis Walker Gilmer, 20 January 1825," *Founders Online*, National Archives, <https://founders.archives.gov/documents/Jefferson/98-01-02-4890>). Evidently, no such catalog existed, nor was one forthcoming. This necessitated John Vaughn Kean's catalog listing this first shipment of books. Kean's catalog also contains entries for books sent by Bohn's successor as the University's bookseller, Cummings & Hilliard of Boston. Most of these later arrivals are classed in a subsection of Kean's catalog labeled, "supplementary catalog"; these later arrivals, and Cumming & Hilliard's role in supplying books is discussed below.

57. A letter dated April 8, 1825, survives that appoints "William Hilliard, Agent for the said University, to procure the said books, and attend to their care, transportation and delivery, at the said University" ("Thomas Jefferson to William Hilliard, 8 April 1825," *Founders Online*, National Archives, <https://founders.archives.gov/documents/Jefferson/98-01-02-5121>).

58. "William Hilliard to Thomas Jefferson, 16 July 1825," *Founders Early Access*, <https://rotunda.upress.virginia.edu/founders/default.xqy?keys=FOEA-print-04-02-02-4400>. Jefferson evidently jotted down several titles from this enclosed catalog, some of which were eventually acquired for the University's library. See "Thomas Jefferson's List of Books for Hilliard, 14 July 1824," *Founders Early Access*, <https://rotunda.upress.virginia.edu/founders/default.xqy?keys=FOEA-print-04-02-02-4406>.

and assent but enclosing no catalog. This means that from September 1824 Hilliard was awaiting Jefferson's itemized order in Boston. While Hilliard had enclosed "a Catalogue of a small part of my recent importations" with his 14 July letter, he left the decision to Jefferson, whose reputation for discernment in books and libraries no doubt preceded his reply. "[W]hether you should select from this [catalog]," Hilliard wrote, "or give orders for the importation of others, you may depend upon the prompt & faithful execution of such orders, & upon the lowest terms."⁵⁹

What list did Jefferson send to Hilliard? Given that the lost pages of the 1824 catalog listed *all* the books Jefferson hoped to acquire for the university's library, it was useless as a list of desiderata by January 1825 when Bohn's 509 books began to arrive in Charlottesville. As we note above, if Jefferson had sent the 1824 catalog (or a copy) to Cummings & Hilliard without first omitting these titles ordered in London, the Rotunda's shelves would have held duplicates, redundancies, or conflicting editions—an embarrassing outcome and a waste of the funds that had been set aside for the purchase of the university's books. To complete the order with Cummings & Hilliard, then, Jefferson had to create yet another list of desiderata, enumerating all of the titles in his 1824 catalog, but omitting books ordered from Bohn and listed in Kean's catalog. This second list of desiderata survives in the Albert and Shirley Small Special Collections Library at the University of Virginia.

This list of desiderata, the **1825 Trist catalog**, would be the last booklist that Jefferson took part in compiling before his death in July 1826.⁶⁰ Like the 1823 Trist catalog before it, the 1825 Trist catalog was penned under Jefferson's direction by Nicholas P. Trist, who by then was well versed in the organizational and bibliographic minutiae of the university's first library. Demonstrating the commercial function of this catalog, at the foot of its last page is a brief note in Jefferson's handwriting explaining that, "the preceding catalogue is that of the books with the purchase of which Mr. Wm. Hilliard is charged on behalf of the University of Virginia." The note is signed, "Th[omas] Jefferson Rector" and dated June 3, 1825. The 1825 Trist catalog was sent to Cummings & Hilliard; William Hilliard acknowledged its receipt in a letter dated 22 June, and books began to arrive from Boston and Europe shortly thereafter.⁶¹

An examination of the 3,113 entries (numbered sequentially in red ink by Hilliard) of the 1825 Trist catalog reveals that it systematically excludes books that appear in Kean's catalog while replicating many of the entries that appear in Trist's 1823 catalog. It can be inferred that these replicated entries also appeared in the lost 1824 catalog, which was almost certainly Jefferson's and Trist's copy text in compiling the 1825 desiderata for Cummings & Hilliard. This textual

59. William Hilliard to Thomas Jefferson, 16 July 1825, *Founders Early Access*, <https://rotunda.upress.virginia.edu/founders/default.xqy?keys=FOEA-print-04-02-02-4400>.

60. The 1825 Trist Catalog is held in the Albert & Shirley Small Special Collections Library at the University of Virginia, shelf mark MSS 38-747.

61. The first box of books arrived on July 13, 1825. See "John V. Kean to Thomas Jefferson, 13 July 1825," *Founders Online*, National Archives, <https://founders.archives.gov/documents/Jefferson/98-01-02-5374>: "I am requested by the Proctor, to inform you that there is a box here sent from Col Peyton; it is directed to you, at the University & we suppose it to contain books likely, for this Library; But wait your better directions."

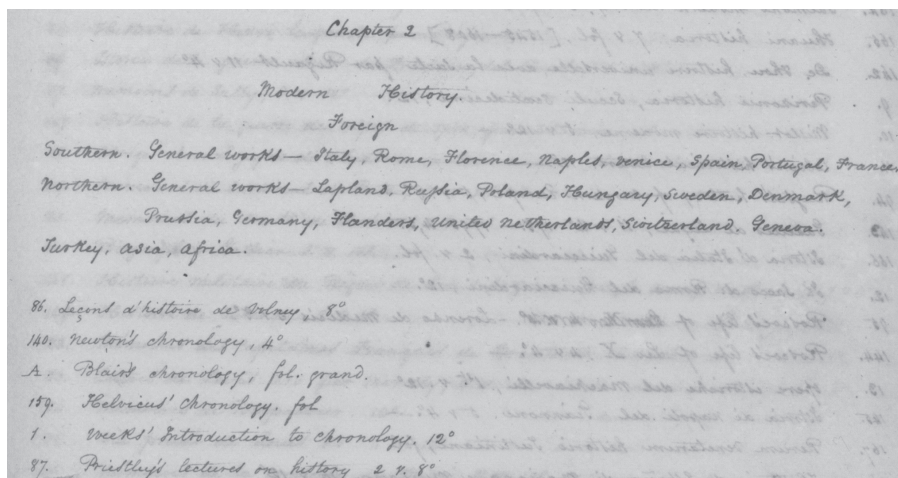


FIGURE 11. 1823 Trist catalog, page 5, showing the first six entries of Chapter 2, “Modern History, Foreign”. Image courtesy of the Thomas Jefferson Collection, Rare Book and Special Collections Division, The Library of Congress.

Chap.	History - Modern - Foreign.						
2.							
	<i>Leçons d'histoire de Volney</i>	—	—	—	—	1129	3
	<i>Newton's Chronology</i>	—	—	—	—	111	4
	<i>L. Blain's John Chronology to 1768</i>	—	—	—	—	111	f
	<i>L. Helvicus' Chronology</i>	—	—	—	—	1121	5
	<i>L. Priestley's lectures on history</i>	—	—	—	—	1132	8

FIGURE 12. 1825 Trist catalog, page 4, showing the first five entries in Chapter 2, “History – Modern – Foreign”, identical to those shown in fig. 11, apart from the omission of “1. Weeks’ Introduction to Chronology, 12°.” Image courtesy of the Albert and Shirley Small Special Collections Library, University of Virginia. MSS 38-747.

evidence spans four booklists (only three of which survive) and confirms that all of the catalogs we examine in this study share a filiation. Namely, the 1825 Trist catalog is an eclectic text, comprising the entries in Jefferson’s lost 1824 list (itself an expanded and revised copy of the Trist 1823 catalog), but omitting books that had been ordered from Bohn by Gilmer and listed in Kean’s 1825 catalog.⁶² Evidence for this filiation via selective recopying and methodical omission abounds. Figures 11 and 12 collate corresponding entries in the second subject chapter

62. The theorized pattern of hybrid and selective copying that produced the 1825 Trist catalog can be expressed formulaically. That is, if n = the contents of the 1825 Trist catalog, i = the contents of the lost 1824 catalog, and z = the contents of the 1825 John Vaughn Kean catalog, then $n = i - z$.

("Modern History, Foreign") of the 1823 and 1825 Trist catalogs. These respective sections list many of the same books in approximately the same order; and the arrangement of the entries' content—title, format, and occasionally volume count—is roughly equivalent. The sole difference is the removal of Weeks' Introduction to Chronology, a 12mo, from the 1825 list. The simplest explanation for these points of similarity is that the 1823 and 1825 Trist documents share a textual filiation, with Jefferson's lost 1824 desiderata occupying the intermediary place.

The first entries in Jefferson's chapter on British History offer more evidence (figs. 13 and 14). Here again, the order of the entries in the 1823 Trist catalog is replicated in the 1825 Trist catalog—a copy of the Domesday book opens the chapter, followed by Camden's *Britannia* (the later list omits the Latin edition that appears in the 1823 Trist catalog, preferring Gibson's English translation), and ending with Sheringham's *De Anglorum Gentis Origine* [*On the Origin of the English People*]. There are discrepancies, however. To the later list, Jefferson added Thomas Hearne's edition of Leland's *Itinerary* and *Collectanea* and omitted Verstegan's [*Restitution of Decayed Intelligence in*] *Antiquities*. In the second case, the reasoning behind Jefferson's omission is clear: a copy of Verstegan's book is listed in the 1825 John Vaughn Kean catalog, ordered from Bohn by Gilmer and delivered the year before. Listing it again in the later catalog would have authorized Cummings & Hilliard to purchase a duplicate copy. The addition of the two titles by Leland demonstrates another category of revision undertaken by Jefferson as he prepared the university's first library—that is, the addition of titles never owned by Jefferson and therefore not listed in the 1823 Trist catalog. This evidence of addition and omission encapsulates Jefferson's scribal method in compiling the lost 1824 catalog, which sits between the 1823 and 1825 Trist catalogs, both chronologically and textually. Working with Trist's 1823 catalog as a basis-text, Jefferson copied out a more complete collection in the 1824 catalog, adding titles or modifying editions to update his library for a modern university and its students. Trist then copied this fuller list, omitting titles in Kean's 1825 catalog, to form the final 1825 catalog sent to Cummings & Hilliard.

Perhaps the strongest evidence for the 1825 Trist catalog's systematic omission of books ordered from Bohn and listed in Kean's catalog appears in its final chapter. The last chapter of the 1823 Trist catalog, "Polygraphical," lists copies of Bacon's *Works* and *Advancement of Learning* followed by copies of Locke's *Works* and *Familiar Letters* (Locke's *Posthumous Works* and "a collection of his pieces" are nested below these titles, with a parenthetical note indicating that they appear "in op.": *in operibus*, or in the multivolume *Works*) (fig. 15). After Locke appears Milton's *Prose Works* in two volumes and a copy of King James's *Works*. Collating this section of the 1823 Trist catalog with the corresponding section of the 1825 Trist catalog, however, reveals that Jefferson ordered no works by Locke or Bacon from Cummings & Hilliard. Instead, in the 1825 Trist catalog Milton's *Prose Works* and King James's *Works* follow Cassiodori *Op[era]. Omn[ia].*, with no intervening entries (the omission of Andrew Dalzel's two *Collectanea*, listed above Bacon's *Works* in the 1823 Trist catalog, is due apparently to Jefferson's decision not to acquire it for the university's library) (fig. 16). This would have amounted to a significant oversight: Jefferson revered both Bacon and Locke—indeed,

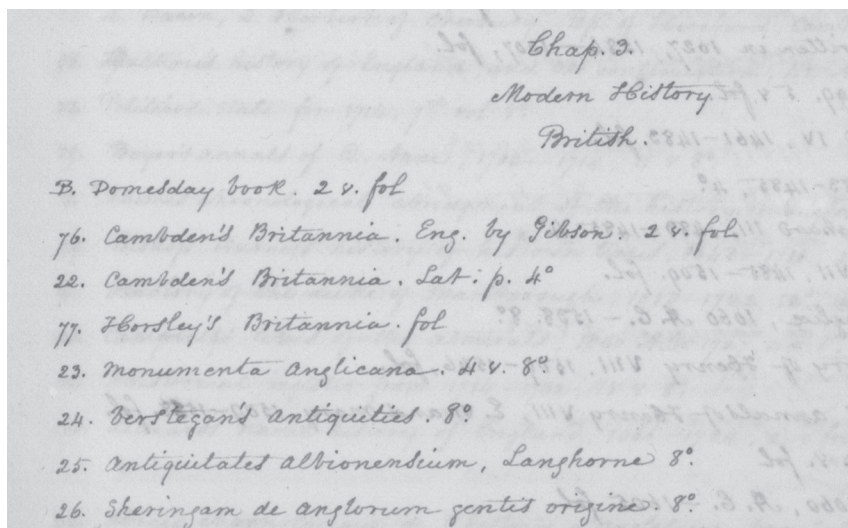


FIGURE 13. 1823 Trist catalog, page 11, showing the first eight entries of chapter 3, "Modern History, British." Image courtesy of the Thomas Jefferson Collection, Rare Book and Special Collections Division, The Library of Congress.

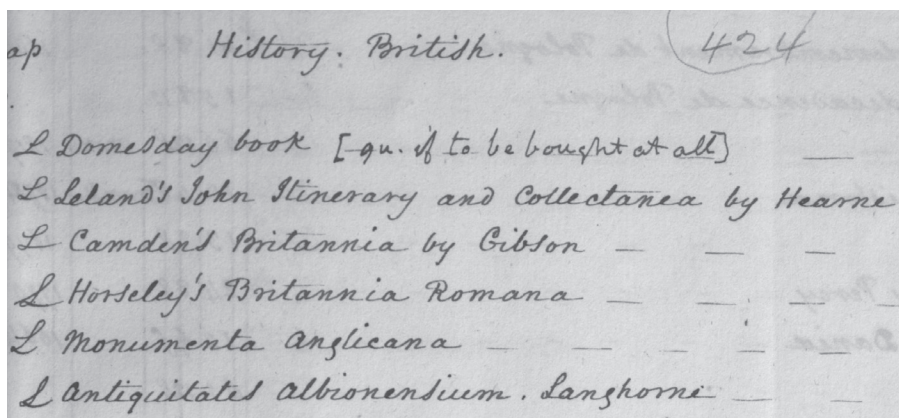


FIGURE 14. 1825 Trist catalog, page 7, showing the first seven entries of chapter 3, "Modern History, British," identical to those listed in fig. 13, apart from the omission of "24. Verstegan's antiquities, 8°." Image courtesy of the Albert and Shirley Small Special Collections Library, University of Virginia. MSS 38-747.

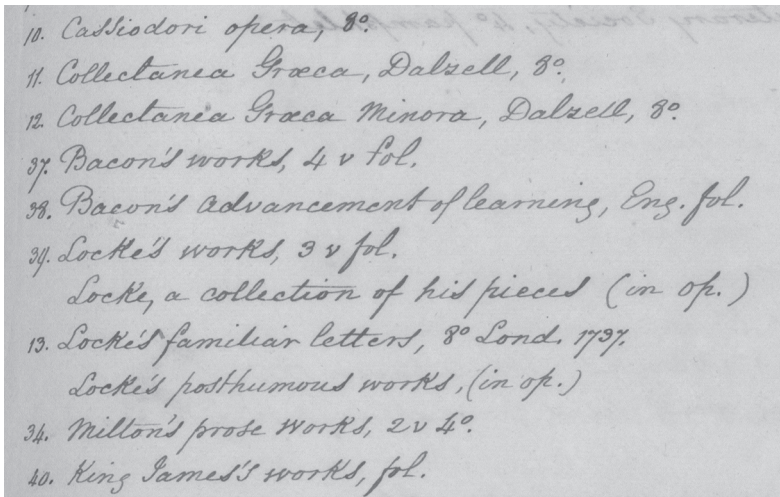


FIGURE 15. 1823 Trist Catalog, page 113, showing works by Francis Bacon and John Locke in "Chapter 44, Polygraphical." Image courtesy of the Thomas Jefferson Collection, Rare Book and Special Collections Division, The Library of Congress.

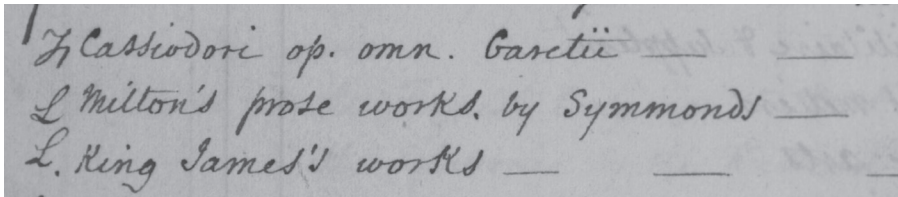


FIGURE 16. 1825 Trist Catalog, page [94], showing the omission of works by Francis Bacon and John Locke from "Chapter 42, Polygraphical." Image courtesy of the Albert and Shirley Small Special Collections Library, University of Virginia. MSS 38-747.

none of his libraries or booklists were without their works.⁶³ But this was not a lapse in Jefferson's usual preferences; rather, Gilmer had ordered multi-volume editions of both Bacon's and Locke's *Works* from Bohn, both of which were duly listed in the 1825 Kean catalog after their arrival in Charlottesville (fig. 17). Including entries for either Bacon or Locke in the 1825 Trist catalog would have resulted in the purchase of duplicates of both authors.

There are exceptions to the patterns of copying and omission that govern our proposed filiation between both Trist catalogs, Jefferson's lost 1824 catalog, and the 1825 Kean catalog. For example, the 1825 Trist catalog includes an entry

63. Douglas Wilson writes, "Locke was one of Jefferson's greatest idols and ... [Locke's *Two Treatises on Government*] was repeatedly recommended by him and pronounced 'perfect as far as it goes.'" Wilson, Douglas L. "Sowerby Revisited: The Unfinished Catalogue of Thomas Jefferson's Library." *The William and Mary Quarterly* 41, no. 4 (October 1984): 615.

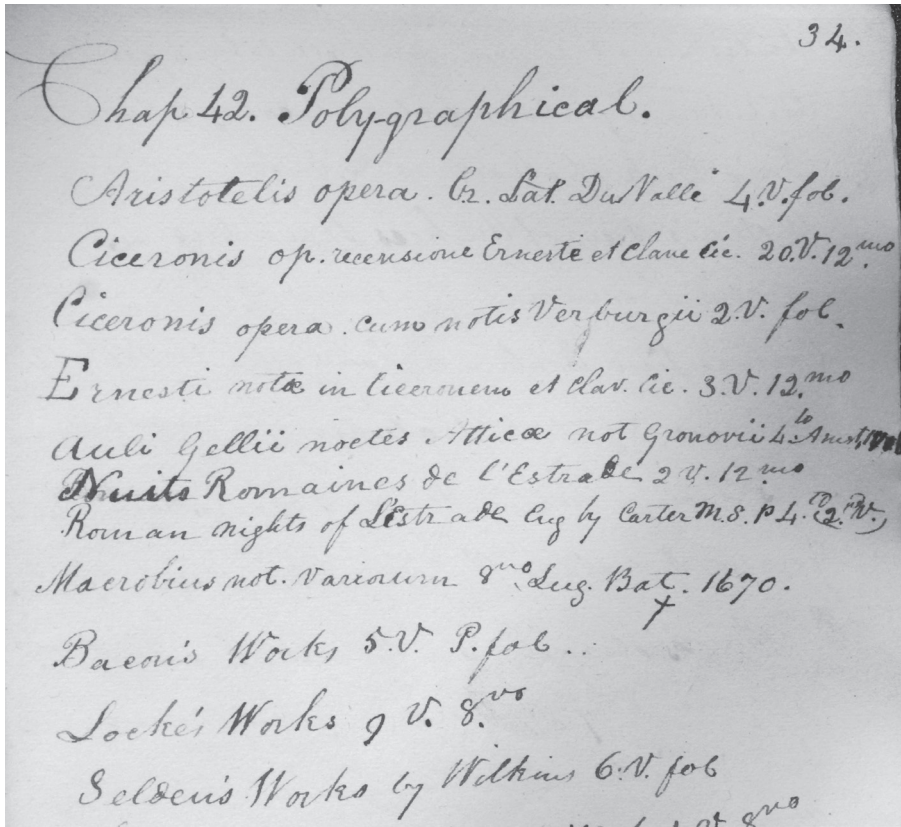


FIGURE 17. 1825 John Vaughn Kean catalog, page 34, showing multi-volume works by Francis Bacon and John Locke in "Chapter 42, Polygraphical." Image courtesy of the Albert and Shirley Small Special Collections Library, University of Virginia. RG-12/12/1.161.

for Smeaton's *Narrative of the Building and a Description of the Construction of Edystone Lighthouse*, despite the fact that Gilmer had ordered a copy from Bohn. Other discrepancies in corresponding sections of the 1823 and 1825 Trist catalogs are likely to remain unexplained due to the loss of the 1824 catalog, which recorded Jefferson's revisions to the earlier list, made to ensure the university was supplied with current editions, smaller formats, or books otherwise more suitable to the university's needs.⁶⁴ In most cases, the editions that Jefferson had purchased decades earlier and that were listed in his earlier catalogs (including the 1823 Trist catalog and the 1815 printed catalog it copied) had been superseded. And while the 1825 Trist catalog indicates that Jefferson attempted to rectify this by

64. Jefferson's preference for books in octavo format is well documented. See, for example, "Thomas Jefferson to William Hilliard, 16 September 1825," *Founders Online*, National Archives, <https://founders.archives.gov/documents/Jefferson/98-01-02-5537>.

researching and ordering later editions or new titles on familiar subjects, we cannot know the full extent of the revisions Jefferson made without the 1824 catalog on hand.⁶⁵

As with any comparatively complex textual genealogy involving multiple copy texts—some of which, in this case, remain unknown (Jefferson's "excellent catalogues"), or are lost—the evidence supports interpretation, not demonstrable proof. Nevertheless, the common textual evidence across these catalogs supports a line of textual descent moving from the 1823 Trist catalog, through the 1825 Kean catalog, and into the 1825 Trist catalog—indicating, in other words, that the 1823 Trist catalog was compiled for the purpose of planning and ordering the University of Virginia's first library. By collating the contents of these documents, we see Jefferson, Trist, Kean, and the university's booksellers collaborating to selectively reinscribe the original 1823 Trist catalog to form a final list of the university's first books. This final list—sent to Cummings & Hilliard in June, 1825 and returned on 11 July, 1826 with a letter from William Hilliard terminating their contract—is not only linked to Jefferson's original 1812 fair copy (and, ultimately, the 1783 catalog before it), but was its textual descendant.⁶⁶ In light of this new evidence concerning the seven catalogs that we have examined here, our stemma tracing their filiation takes final shape (fig. 18).

The stemma in figure 18 can be reduced to a narrative that situates the seven catalogs we examine above in four distinct phases of work: first, the 1815 printed catalog and the 1783 manuscript catalog formed a dual copy text for Trist's 1823 manuscript catalog; second, the 1823 Trist catalog served as the primary copy text for Jefferson's lost 1824 catalog, supplemented by Jefferson's retirement library catalog, Jefferson's correspondence with James Madison, George Ticknor, and others, as well as Jefferson's collection of "excellent" bookseller's catalogs and several lists of books supplied by the university's first professors (see *supra* note 41); third, the John Vaughn Kean catalog, finished in May 1825, derived its format and organizational schema from the 1824 catalog, as demonstrated by the rediscovered leaf at the Library of Congress; and fourth, and finally, Trist and Jefferson worked to compile the 1825 Trist catalog, replicating the contents of the

65. Some evidence for Jefferson's revising and updating survives in the 1825 catalog sent to Cummings & Hilliard (Inventory of Books for the University of Virginia, Cummings, Hilliard and Co., 1825-1827, RG-2/1/6.026, Special Collections, University of Virginia, Charlottesville, Va.). For example, next to Phillips Mineralogy, Trist copied a note from Jefferson requesting the "last edition," while next to the entry for La Cépède's edition of Buffon's *Natural History*—70 volumes in 12mo—another note requests that "if the 8^e ed[ition] by La Cépède be as comprehensive, prefer it" (Chapter 11, *Natural History* – Zoology; p. 27).

66. The letter from Cummings & Hilliard closing their contract is UVA MS 11910. Having obtained as many of the books listed in the 1825 Trist catalog as possible, Hilliard observed that "the amount furnished for the purchase of Books, was altogether inadequate to the accomplishment of the Catalogue made out; therefore many Books are omitted, & especially those, the most expensive, and many more, which could not be procured. I had positive instructions from Mr. J not to exceed the sum of 10,000 dollars, & have been studious not to exceed my instructions. The Books already viewed, & those on the way, together with the commission, will amount nearly to the sum appropriated. In some cases, there will probably be found duplicates, which may be handed over to my agent Mr. Jones—Otherwise, I shall expect that none will be returned, as a discretionary power was given, in regard to editions."

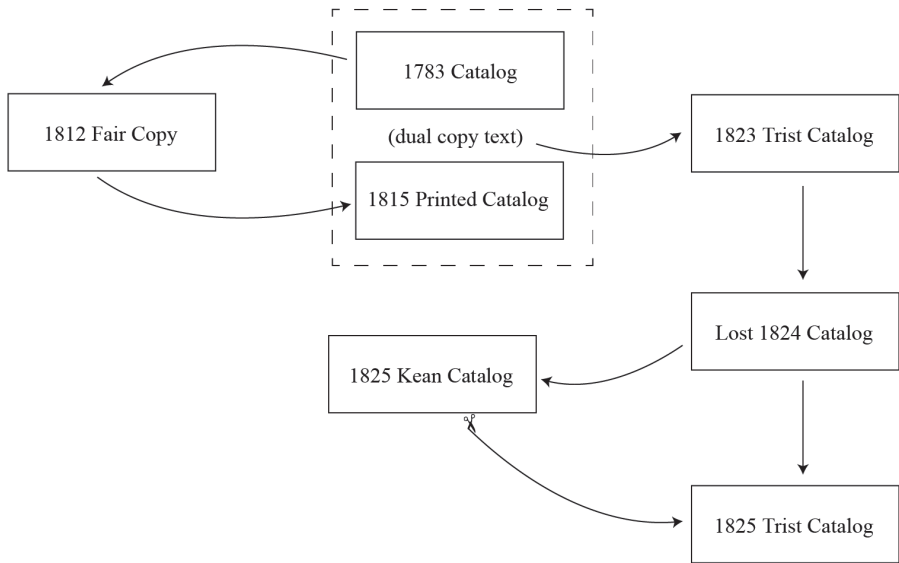


FIGURE 18. The final stemma illustrating the textual filiation that links all seven catalogs we examine in this study.

1824 catalog, but omitting entries for books that had been ordered from Bohn in London or donated to the university by early supporters and subsequently listed in Kean's 1825 catalog.

EPILOGUE: THE UNRECOGNIZED PROVENANCE OF THE 1823 TRIST CATALOG

The textual evidence inhering in these seven catalogs demonstrates that each represents a phase of work in Jefferson's planning the University of Virginia's first library. The idea that Trist's and Jefferson's work on the 1823 catalog was intended only to reconstruct a lost order for Jefferson's books is not supported by the catalogs that Jefferson penned or planned subsequently. Each of these later lists is textually and formally related to Trist's 1823 manuscript, tracing a line of filiation from Jefferson's original 1783 manuscript catalog through to the final list sent to Cummings & Hilliard in June 1825. The newly uncovered evidence supporting this filiation is not only textual, however. In a letter sent to Trist on October 4, 1826, James Madison—then Rector of the University—offered Trist the job of Secretary to the Board of Visitors and an additional \$50 “in consideration of yr. service in relation to the Catalogue for the Library.”⁶⁷ This offered payment implies that Trist's work on Jefferson's catalogs—both the 1823

67. “James Madison to Nicholas P. Trist, 4 October 1826,” *Founders Online*, National Archives, <https://founders.archives.gov/documents/Madison/99-02-02-0757>.

manuscript and the 1825 manuscript that followed—was not only in service to Jefferson, but was done rather in a semi-official capacity for the university. In other words, the timing of Trist's commission to compile the 1823 catalog was driven primarily by Jefferson's interest in developing a final list of books that would form the University of Virginia's first library. In the event, Trist declined the payment, explaining that his "motive in undertaking it was to gratify Mr Jefferson ... and as part of that gratuitously done by him for the Un[iversit]y."⁶⁸

A further clue regarding the origin and purpose of the 1823 Trist catalog hides in plain sight in Gilreath and Wilson's 1989 account: their observation that the catalog was for many years "mistakenly labeled as a catalog of the library at the University of Virginia." Closer examination of the catalog's provenance and the manuscript itself reveals that this association was not a "mistake," but rather was based on a clearly traceable history that connects the catalog to the university rather than to Jefferson's personal estate. If Trist's manuscript had been privately prepared for Thomas Jefferson, it would most likely have been retained by Jefferson's family among Jefferson's other personal papers and ultimately consigned to the Massachusetts Historical Society along with the rest of the Coolidge Collection—including the 1783 catalog. This was not the case. As Gilreath himself writes in the introduction to his edited collection *The Judgment of Experts*, "provenance is the one unfailing guide when used in conjunction with a critically intelligent examination of the physical properties and text of any document ... when considered along with other methods of checking a document, it will certainly improve the reliability of any conclusion."⁶⁹

Our early examination of the 1823 Trist catalog was conducted using a scan of the document, but when we later examined the manuscript in person we found what is perhaps the catalog's most tantalizing piece of provenance evidence. On the front pastedown in the original binding, the number "41" appears penciled in the upper left corner (fig. 19a). This number matches the method and placement of shelf-marking used in the University of Virginia's first library (see fig. 19b), suggesting that the number indicates the book's subject chapter and shelving location in the Rotunda or in Pavilion VII—a structure on the University of Virginia's quadrilateral "lawn" that housed the university's books before the Rotunda was completed and the books installed under its dome.⁷⁰ While the 1823 Trist catalog would likely have been classified in Chapter 40, "Bibliography," the penciled "41" could be the result of human error: Chapter 40 contained only five titles prior to 1826. In contrast, the adjacent Chapter 41, "Philology," contained over 100 titles. In installing the constituent volumes of these two chapters onto their shelves and labelling them, books from Chapter 40 could have been easily

68. "Nicholas P. Trist to James Madison, 5 October 1826," *Founders Online*, National Archives, <https://founders.archives.gov/documents/Madison/99-02-02-0762>.

69. Gilreath, "Introduction," *The judgment of experts: essays and documents about the investigation of the forging of the Oath of a freeman*, ed. Gilreath (Worcester: American Antiquarian Society, 1991), 5.

70. On early shelf marks that survive at the University of Virginia, see Samuel V. Lemley, Neal D. Curtis, and Madeline Zehnder, "Historical Shelf Marks as Sources for Institutional Provenance Research: Reconstructing the University of Virginia's Rotunda Library," *Papers of the Bibliographical Society of America* 118, no. 1 (March 2024): 79-101.

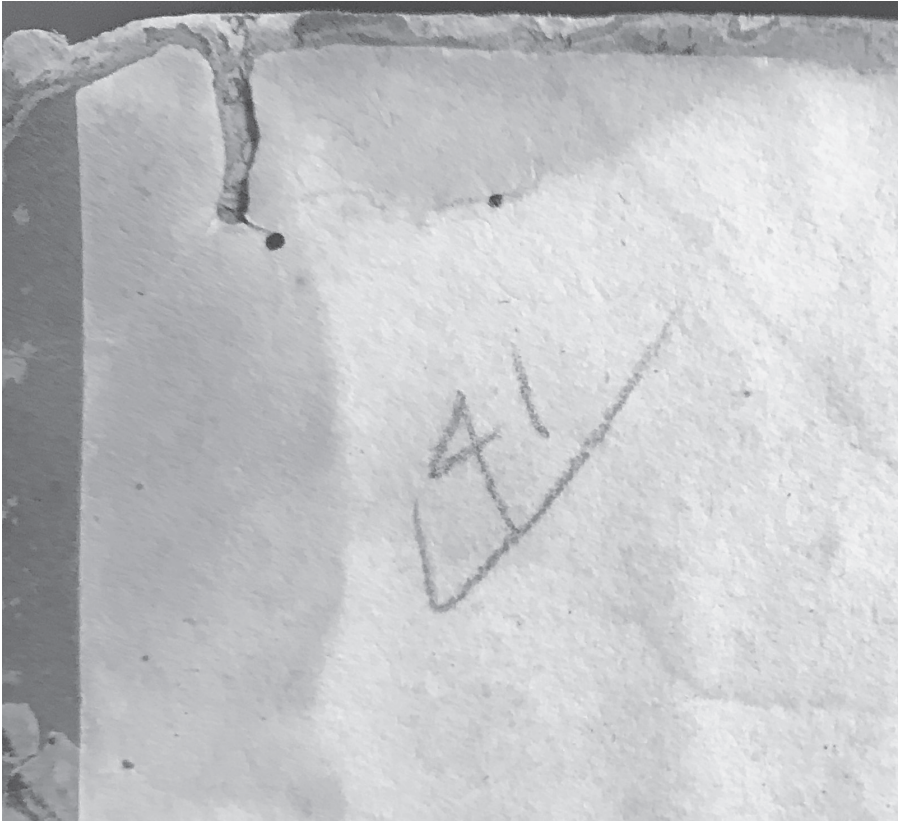


FIGURE 19A. 1823 Trist catalog, front pastedown, showing a shelf mark “41,” indicating its subject and shelving location in the University of Virginia’s Library. Image courtesy of the Thomas Jefferson Collection, Rare Book and Special Collections Division, The Library of Congress.

mixed in with those from Chapter 41, and shelved together. Whatever its cause, the notation suggests that the 1823 Trist catalog should be directly associated with the library of the University of Virginia.

In fact, the 1823 Trist catalog did not remain with Jefferson but was kept at the university as late as 1834. On this point the provenance evidence in the catalog itself is unequivocal. The original cover bears a later label that states “University of Virginia”; we believe this was added when the book was donated to the Library of Congress in 1917. More revealing is the presence on the front flyleaf of a date, name, and place, all clearly inscribed: “Pearce L. Lewis of Georgia, 1834, University of Virginia.” Lewis also tried his pencil on the flyleaf, inscribing his name faintly three times down the page and tracing his initials (PLL) in the bottom right quarter of the page (fig. 20). Pearce Lewis was an undergraduate student at the University of Virginia studying Moral Philosophy and



FIGURE 19B. A similar shelf mark “41,” appears on the front free endpaper of a copy of *Anthologia Graeca, Sive Poetarum Graecorum Lusus* held in the Albert and Shirley Small Special Collections Library at the University of Virginia. This copy was originally shelved in the Rotunda. Image courtesy of the Albert and Shirley Small Special Collections Library, University of Virginia. PA3458.A2 1794, vol. 1.

Law in the university’s 11th session, 1834-35.⁷¹ The signs of his interaction with the catalog indicate that the volume remained at the university until at least that date. Thereafter, Lewis appears to have taken the catalog to his native Georgia, where it remained until 1916 when it was found by Frederick (Frank) Goodell in 1916 while he was serving as camp librarian at Camp Wheeler near Macon.

The provenance and textual evidence in the manuscript suggest that Douglas Wilson’s conclusion that the 1823 catalog “proves to be a copy of the catalog of the library sold to Congress with the entries in Jefferson’s order and corrected in his own hand” is then only one part of a fascinating story.⁷² On the basis of the materials we present here, we propose that the 1823 Trist manuscript was actu-

71. *Catalogue of the Officers and Students of the University of Virginia, Session of 1834-35* (Charlottesville: Moseley & Tompkins, 1835), 7.

72. Wilson, *Jefferson’s Books*, 44.

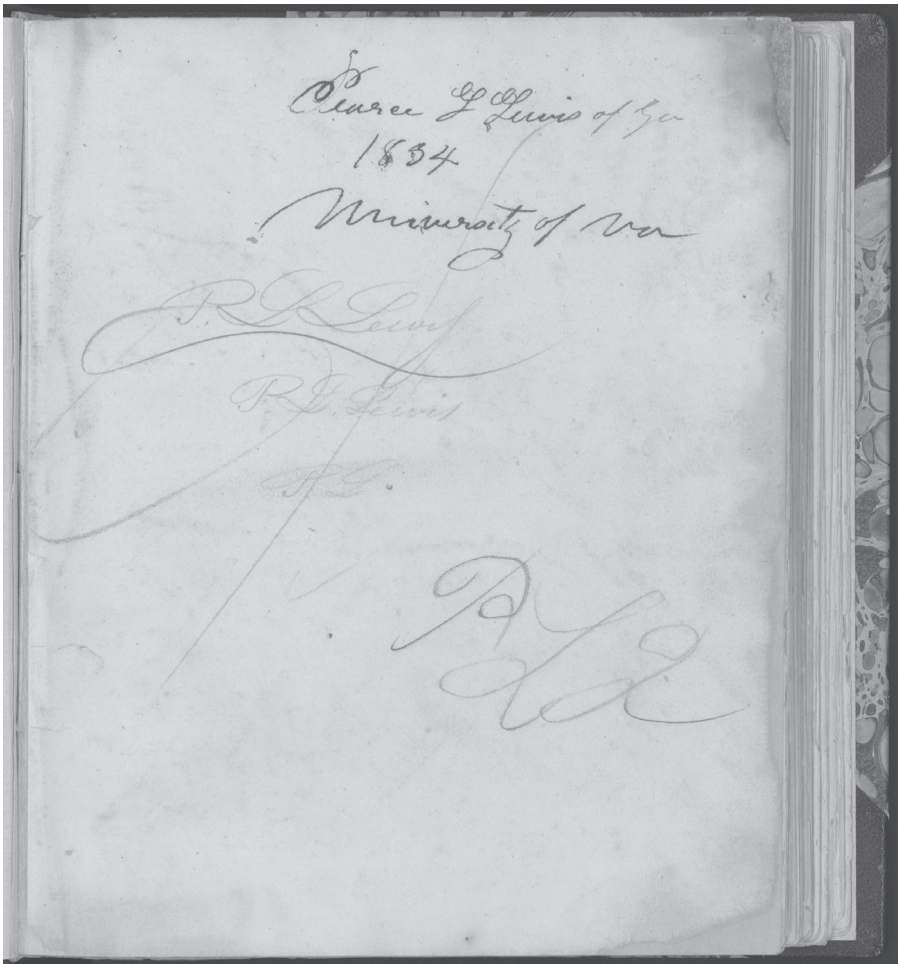


FIGURE 20. 1823 Trist catalog, front free endpaper, showing pen trials and inscriptions written by Pierce L. Lewis, a student at the University of Virginia. Image courtesy of the Thomas Jefferson Collection, Rare Book and Special Collections Division, The Library of Congress.

ally prepared for the university in the earliest phase of the library's planning and was retained by the university until its removal by Pearce Lewis. Yet we remain alive to other possibilities. Millicent Sowerby observed in her introduction to the *Catalogue of the Library of Thomas Jefferson* (1952) that "the number of manuscripts to be read and examined was so overwhelming that it is impossible not to suggest that the student of Jefferson will be repaid by further reading of these, or that the publication by Princeton of the volumes of *The Papers of Thomas Jefferson* will

not provide undiscovered material.”⁷³ Her remarks have proved prescient. If we have succeeded in expanding Gilreath and Wilson’s reading of the catalogs, it is in part because we have adduced additional information from manuscripts in the Albert and Shirley Small Special Collections Library at the University of Virginia and the Rare Books Division at the Library of Congress as well as in newly published Jefferson correspondence made available through Early Access documents and the Jefferson Papers project. As future bibliographers make additional discoveries about the University of Virginia’s library and develop new methodologies—particularly around the interpretation of provenance evidence—we look forward to reading the yet unknown stories they have to tell.

73. Sowerby, *Catalogue of the Library of Thomas Jefferson*, xiv.